



The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

- Volume 2 -

*The Eastern Valleys and the
Fringes of the Desert*

Adam Zertal

The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

Culture and History of the Ancient Near East

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The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

Volume II: The Eastern Valleys and
the Fringes of the Desert

By
Adam Zertal



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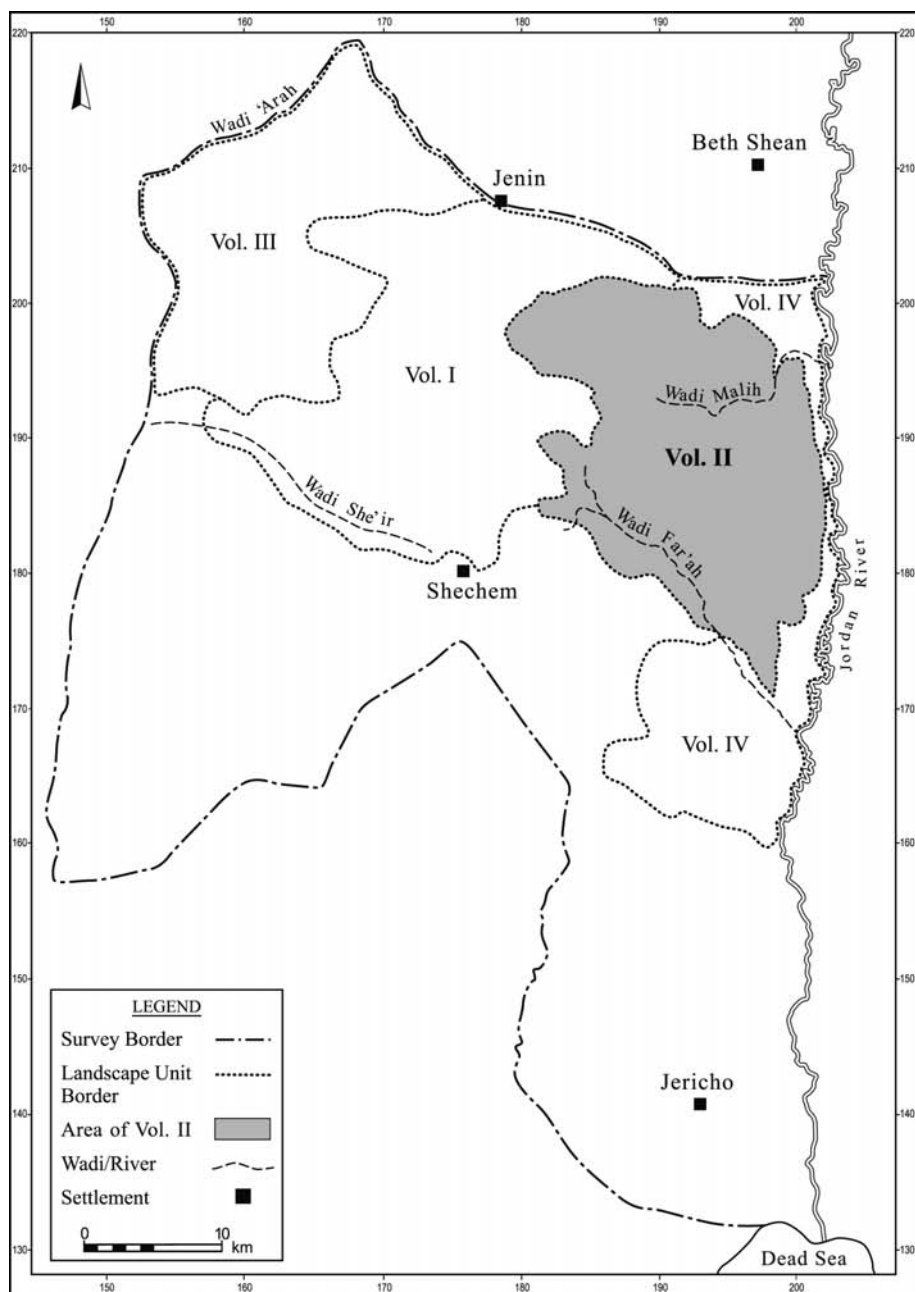
THE STAFF



The Manasseh Survey staff in 2004. Standing, from left to right: Amit Shadman, Dror Ben-Yosef, Murad Tabar, Haim Winter, Shraga Hashman, Adam Zertal, Yael Leder, Maya Nissan, Daphna Ulman, Michal Oren-Demsky, Moshe Einav. Sitting, from left to right: David Eitam, Oren Cohen and Ron Be'eri. Not present: Gil Cooper and Shai Bar.



The Manasseh Survey staff in 1998, from left to right: Murad Tabar, Arad Haggi, Gil Cooper, Adam Zertal, Haim Cohen, Shraga Hashman, Nivi Mirkam and Moshe Einav.



The Area of the Manasseh Survey, divided into volumes of publication.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS USED OVER THE BOOK

a.s.a = above surrounding area	Kh. = Khirbeh (t)
a.s.l. = above sea level	Km = kilometer
BCE, B. C. E. = Before Common Era	LBA = Late Bronze Age
b.s.a = below surrounding area	LR = Late Roman Period
b.s.l = below sea level	Lt = light
bl = black	LU = Landscape Unit/s
br = brown	m = metre, metres
Byz = Byzantine Period	MA = Middle Ages
CE, C. E. = Common Era	MBA = Middle Bronze Age
Chal = Chalcolithic Period	Misc = miscellaneous
CP = Cooking Pot	Mod = modern
Cu m = Cubic meter	No, nos = number, numbers
dec = decorated, decoration	Ott = Ottoman Period
dk = dark	PEF = Palestine Exploration Fund
EBA = Early Bronze Age	Per = Persian Period
EM = Early Moslem Period	pk = pink
EP, E. P. = Elevation Point	rd = red
ER = Early Roman Period	sq. km = square kilometer
gr = gray	sq. m = square meter
Hel = Hellenistic Period	wh = white
HM = Hole mouth (jar)	yel = yellow
IrA = Iron Age	

PREFACE

Three years have passed since the publication of the first volume of *The Manasseh Hill Country Survey* in English, and fifteen years since the first publication in Hebrew; we are honored to present the second volume in the English series to the public of researchers and readers.

The eastern valleys and the desert fringe of Manasseh (henceforth - East Manasseh) are an extensive region, stretching over an area of 500 sq km and more. In character, the area resembles the other desert fringe regions of the Holy Land: the fringes of Ephraim and Benjamin, parts of the Judean Desert and the Negev Highlands. As in the other open regions, here, too, precipitation is less frequent than in the Mediterranean region, and thus perennial sources of water are of such importance that settlements through the generations concentrated around them; the population of East Manasseh can be divided, as in other places, into nomadic, semi-nomadic and permanent settlers. As in the Negev again, an important characteristic is the changing "waves" of settlement over the long periods of nomadism.

In accordance with the pattern set for publication of the *Manasseh Hill Country Survey* (Zertal 1993b; 1997), in each of the volumes a different, extensive region of the country has been researched, the defini-

tion of which relies on geomorphic and historical principles rather than division into maps. The information on the site and its environs, divided into archaeological, historical, geographical and ecological-environmental characteristics, has been considerably broadened and revised in this volume. Attention was paid to illustrations as well, as was begun in the first volume. These illustrations – plans, photographs of the place and its environs, drawings of pottery and other finds, and photographs of findings – shed light on many varied facets of the site.

The interested reader will find the detailing of the principles of the *Manasseh Hill Country Survey* and its publications in the first chapter of this volume, and more extensive information in the introduction to the first volume.

The second volume is published in a similar pattern, but with some alterations and additions. The innovations are these: in the introduction a short historical survey has been added, which will offer the reader who is unfamiliar with the details of the area a broad historical picture of the settlement and geographic historical identification notes. Attention is paid, and much work has been invested, in measuring the sites and drafting plans; it became apparent that the architecture of the site is the foundation

stone for understanding the settlement and its historical and social characteristics. All plans were measured by the survey staff, and their number was increased eight-fold: from 15 plans in the first volume, to 140 and more in the second one. This is due both to the expertise of the team and to the fact that the area was tranquil during the years of the first *Intifada* (1987-1993), making possible uninterrupted work. In addition, the early architecture is better preserved in East Manasseh than in the Mediterranean zone. The supplement of features was greatly enlarged; in this volume, an extensive series of aerial photographs of the various sites was added.

Each individual site is published, as in the first volume, in the following order: title, characteristics, description, ceramic finds, information and supposition from literary sources, previous surveys and bibliography; here, too, a pottery plates and other findings are presented for most of the sites; the settlement was photographed from the air and the ground, in such a way as to create an "album" of the sites. The value of this photo album will rise in the future, as a large proportion of the places will become built-up modern villages, towns, and cities.

An important, significant addition is the new appendices. The first, the processing and publishing of prehistoric material, was done by Haim Winter. He worked on the

flint tools and utensils collected during the survey, identifying, drawing and processing them scientifically; this action, lacking in the first volume, is also absent from most of the other surveys of the Holy Land. Although a few flint tools had been found previously during the survey, only with the inclusion of H. Winter in the staff could the prehistoric survey be based on methodological principles. While there is still a need for a comprehensive, complementary, prehistoric survey, Winter's work for the first time illuminates an entire, unknown region in a new "prehistoric light".

The coin appendix, the work of Ya'akov Yanai, is published here in a form similar to that of the first volume, with the addition of photographs of selected coins.

The survey of East Manasseh was conducted over 14 years, beginning in 1980 and ending in 1994, together with the process of revisiting along the years. Just as the Mediterranean regions of the Manasseh Hill Country were largely unknown to research, so was East Manasseh; about 80 per cent of its sites are revealed here for the first time. Over the course of the years, the area was surveyed in its entirety, step by step. Over 500 days of field work were invested, with the participation of three to twelve staff members each time. The sites and their phenomena were recorded precisely, and the illustrative material was prepared.

Over the years we learned to love the region we were researching, one of the richest and most enthralling of those in the Holy Land; the survey became, for the people involved, both a way of life and a second home.

And finally, in these times of rapid political changes, the importance of our research increases, and the urgency of completing the field work and publishing the findings of the entire series is compelling.

A multi-annual archaeological survey requires full cooperation and team work. At the beginning of this second volume, I would like to thank once again all the participants who worked on the survey, processed the material and prepared it for publication:

My friend and colleague, the late Nivi Mirkam, participated continually in all the work of the survey from the beginning to the year 2000; Shraga Hashman also participated continually in the work and contributed his abilities and his good temper; Idan Shaked participated over a period of six years; David Eitam participated with regularity in the field work; Haim Winter processed the prehistoric material; and the following people, listed alphabetically, each worked for over a year:

Yasmin Bar-Maor, Shai Bar, Ron Be'eri, Dror Ben-Yosef, Tamar Charpak, Haim Cohen, Oren

Cohen, Gil Cooper, Ilana Gonen, Tsach Horovitz, Per Jacobsen, Rafi Kimchi, Zvi Koenigsberg, Nirit Lavie-Alon, No'ah Maestro, Natalie Masika, Rinat Nevo, Sarah (Ketti) Rafael, Yonathan Rand, Shlomo Sender, Michal Shelach, Liah Tremmer and Adi Ziv.

The following also participated: Alvaro, Miriam Belmaker, Pinchas Cohen, Oded Dagai, Tamir Dagan, Meirav Hofi, Yossi Mizrahi, Ronen and Gal Mirkam, Eldad Oren, Sari Pinkas, Mordechai Pozen, Dror Segal, Nurit Shacharon, Nati Tsameret, Amotz, Imri, Rotem and Navot Zertal.

In this volume, I also wish to thank Kibbutz Ein-Shemer for the services it provided; The Zinman Institute of Archaeology, Haifa University, for being the scientific home and patron for both the field work and its publication; to the regional councils of Shomeron and the Jordan Valley for the aid they provided; to Nesher which performed the aerial photography and Nesher's pilot, Mr. Benny Daniel; to Prof. Danny Kaufman, who identified some of the prehistoric sites; to Nati Tsameret of the Society for Preservation of Nature who accompanied several of the tours.

Special, heartfelt thanks go to the Cooper family, Ziva and Gil of Moshav Argaman, and their children, who provided great help and their home was the principal work base for many years.

Special thanks to the Scandinavian Church for Israel and the Bible, with Gru and Bruno Wenske and Dr. Magne Smith, who helped us a lot.

Many people took part in preparing, publishing and financing the present volume. Following is a list of the principal contributors, and all deserve cordial thanks:

The aerial photographs were taken by Moshe Weinberg; The photographs of the findings were taken by Arie Ginaton; The photographs of the coins were taken by David Shkolovski; The ceramics illustrations were drawn by Imri Zertal, Zarazah Friedman and Sapir Haad; The flint tools were drawn by Haim Winter, Zarazah Friedman and Sapir Haad; The sketches and maps were drawn by Sapir Haad and Yehudit Dekel;

The computerized maps were prepared by Sapir Haad; the black and white printing of photographs was done by Malka Weinberg; Sapir Haad made also some of the drawings, redrew all the maps in Eng-

lish, paged the text and prepared it for print.

And, finally, to the translator into English, Ruthie Ben-Mayor, who made an excellent translation in a field which was unknown to her.

Many thanks to the following:

To my friend, Atty. Avraham Ben Naphtali, and to the Leon David Asseo Fund. The scholarships that were awarded to the outstanding students aided the research work all along the way;

Special thanks go to all the family members of the survey participants, without whose patience and support we could not have maintained the survey work during this difficult period.

And last but not least, to my mentor and friend, the late Benjamin Mazar, who despite the difficulties he withstood, was an important friend and consultant during all the work. Regretfully, he did not live to see the publication of this volume.

A.Z., Fall 2006

PART ONE

INTRODUCTIONS

CHAPTER ONE

THE SCIENTIFIC PRINCIPLES OF THE MANASSEH HILL COUNTRY SURVEY

A full and detailed explanation of the above mentioned principles can be found in the first volume of this series (Zertal 2004, 13-23; Zertal and Greenberg 1983; Zertal and Mirkam 2000). We will briefly repeat these six principles here, with a description of how each site is listed.

1. Choice of territory

A relatively large territory was chosen, the boundaries of which have a geomorphologic and/or historical basis (such as the boundaries of the Biblical allotments). These boundaries encompass a large area which is not divisible by arbitrary maps.

2. The division into landscape units

Each volume is divided into landscape units ranging in area from 10 to 70 sq km. This division is based on four factors: the great variety of the Manasseh Hill Country region; the existence of geographically “enclosed” landscape units, such as valleys; the fact that several small landscape units can easily be joined to form larger units for purposes of analysis; and the existence of a former historical basis (e.g., the Bibli-

cal districts of Manasseh, the Hellenistic-Roman Period *toparchies* of Sebasteh, Neapolis and Caesarea, etc.).

3. The complete survey

The survey was made on foot with no omissions. All sites and features were recorded. The surveyors were aided by aerial surveying and photographs; for the present volume eight flights were carried out.

4. The separation of sites and features

A distinction was drawn between sites and features. Sites are places where people dwelt in the past. Features are defined as man-made installations or structures: agricultural installations, cisterns, roads, terraces etc. Each of the two types was surveyed and published differently.

5. Site recording

Recording underwent a series of changes, in comparison to customary recording. These are:

- a. Recording was by a system of computerized characteristics;
- b. Geographical names were cited

as part of the record;

c. Ecological data of the site was recorded;

d. The roads and water sources were noted;

e. The potsherds were collected in a controlled way and recorded by periods and percentages.

For field recording a special form was created. Each site was processed and registered according to the following divisions: site numbers; names in Hebrew, English and Arabic; computerized characteristics in two columns; descriptive text; pottery finds; other finds; surveyors' opinion of the site; previous surveys and bibliography.

The registration of each site includes the following:

1. **Site number:** including the serial number (consecutive numbering for each landscape unit, from west to east and from north to south) and the scientific number (see Kochavi 1972, 13).

2. **Site name:** It is based upon the Arabic name as used today by the inhabitants, and the others are transliterations. In some cases other names (such as those derived from the Survey of Western Palestine – SWP) are added.

3. **Reference point:** both according to the Israel grid and UTM grid.

4. **Elevation:** a.s.l. and in relation to the surrounding area.

5. **Type of name:** including four types, depending on the extent of preservation of the original name.

6. **Site type:** nineteen types of sites were defined during the survey. These are according to size (small, medium and large ruin), architecture (enclosure, structure, etc.), and function (farm, fortress, tell, etc.).

7. **Area of the site:** the area (in dunams and acres) on which the structures stood. This is determined by shard scatter and surveyors' estimation.

8. **Topography:** ten basic topographical features where the site is located were determined. An individual site may be located on one or more of these.

9. **Rock and soil type:** rock types (period, formation or group) and soil type of the site and its surroundings. The data comes from geographical and soil maps.

10. **Cultivation:** the present situation (orchard, etc.).

11. **Water and roads:** there were three divisions of this section: number of cistern openings, the nearest perennial water source (spring, stream, etc.) and distance from it in km as the crow flies, and the nearest pathway and distance from it in km.

12. **Visibility:** measured on a scale from 1 to 10 in accordance with the principles detailed in the first volume.

In the second volume, date/s of visit/s by the surveyors to the site and number of potsherds collected are also recorded.

The two columns of characteristics are followed by a verbal description, including the location of the site and description of the visible remains on the surface. The pottery find includes the period and percentage of indicative pottery.

The special finds includes coins, figurines, metal, etc. Following the text is a description either from historical sources or by earlier visitors, an evaluation by the surveyors of the general character of the site and suggestions for identification. The last items mentioned are of earlier surveyors, if there were any, and a bibliography.

CHAPTER TWO

THE GEOGRAPHY AND SETTLEMENT HISTORY OF EAST MANASSEH

A. History of Research

East Manasseh has been one of the lesser-known and lesser-researched areas of the central hill country in particular and of the Holy Land in general. The area lies outside of the usual realms of interest of explorers; it contains almost no famous historical sites; although it is frequently mentioned in the Bible, its conditions for exploration are difficult (oppressive heat in summer, few water sources, etc.).

Most of the explorers who visited the Holy Land in the 19th and 20th centuries CE conducted journeys along set routes (Ben-Arieh 1970). Travelers tended to cross the Manasseh Hill Country along the line that led from Nablus-Shechem to Samaria-Sebasteh, Dothan, the Jezreel Valley, Nazareth and Haifa. This route brought the traveler to the few holy places in the Samaria region connected to the Old and New Testament traditions (Joseph's tomb and Jacob's well in Shechem; Mount Garizim of the Samaritan tradition; Samaria-Sebasteh; Dothan, etc.). The eastern section of the area did not offer additions to this set model.

Explorations and surveys:

Some of the Medieval explorers (Burchard of Mount Zion [1971] and Marino Sanuto [1971]) mentioned a few sites in the area. The Crusader sources also make note of several places, especially those near Nablus-Shechem. Moslem geographers passed by on the road from Shechem to Beth Shean, as did the Jewish traveler Ashtory Haparhi, who visited there at the beginning of the 14th century and described several sites.

In the second half of the 19th century, the "Golden Age" of explorers in the Holy Land, three travelers visited this territory. The first was Edward Robinson, who conducted sporadic journeys in 1838 and 1853 and published his book detailing the finds (original publication of Robinson - 1857; reprint 1970). He descended from Shechem through Wadi Malih, visited Burj el-Malih and esh-Shaqq Valley, and then crossed over into Transjordan. Victor Guérin, the noted French explorer, was the first to conduct a 19th century survey in the area. Guérin's research method (original publication - Guérin 1875; reprint 1969) was based on his visit to most of the sites and

places along which his route passed, and his reports comprise valuable material. Guérin visited the area a short time after the beginning of the British Survey (Survey of Western Palestine, henceforth SWP), but apparently without any connection with it. His first visit to our region lasted five days, taking place April 23-27, 1870. He visited the following places: April 23 – Wadi Far‘ah and its delta, Kh. Makhruq and additional sites in the area; April 24 – Qurn Sartabeh; April 25 – ascended Wadi Far‘ah and departed from there to el-Buqei‘ah, the village of Tammun, Tel el-Far‘ah and back through Wadi Far‘ah; April 26 – through the Jordan Valley to Kh. es-Sakkut; April 27 – Wadi Malih until Burj el-Malih and back to Kh. es-Sakkut.

Guérin returned to the area on 3-4 May, 1870. This time he approached the region from the north and visited Zebabdeh and Tubas Valleys (the villages of Kfer, ‘Aqabeh, Kh. Salhab, Taiyasir and Tubas). On May 4 he visited Kh. Yarzah, Kh. ‘Eynun and Burj el-Far‘ah, and camped at ‘Ain Beidan.

Guérin did not conduct a modern survey, but rather a journey through several sites. The importance of his work was in his short, verbal descriptions of the places and the several traditions he mentioned. In some cases, there is value in his place names and in his geographical historical discussions.

The members of the SWP, C.R. Conder and H.H. Kitchener (1879; 1882; Conder 1876a; 1876b; 1881), visited the area in 1874. As in other districts in the Holy Land, their survey was comprehensive regarding the number of sites they discovered, but their laconic descriptions and lack of dating affected the value of their work. Most of their descriptions consist of terms like “pile of stones”, “walls”, etc. Their illustrative material (photos and plans) is sparse. For example, they note that the elaborate Roman tomb in Taiyasir had already been photographed in 1866, but the photo was not published. Of the entire territory covered in their volume, they published only one very small plan, that of Burj el-Malih.

After Guérin and the SWP, few researchers returned to the area until the Emergency Israeli survey of 1967-1968, conducted after the Six-Day War. In 1940 Glueck (1951, 409-420) visited several sites at the delta of Wadi Far‘ah and in the wadi itself, but that visit was intended merely to complete his work in Transjordan. In the 1960’s the Germans Kappus (1966) and Knierim (1969) conducted brief, selective surveys of the valley of Wadi Far‘ah. In their two published reports 11 sites appear, comprising about one fifth of the sites discovered in the Manasseh Hill Country Survey.

The 1967 Emergency Survey

(Porath 1968; Gophna and Porath 1972; Bar-Adon 1972; Kallai 1972) consisted of two stages: Gophna and Porath visited approximately 50 sites during the summer of 1967, within the area of East Manasseh. In the winter of 1968, in the framework of the second stage (unpublished), Porath (1968) added 26 sites. These 76 sites comprise nearly one quarter of all the sites in the area.

The members of the Emergency Survey visited primarily the sites marked on the maps and those close to the roads and jeep paths. Their site descriptions are short and stereotypical, and in many cases do not mention the full extent of the site. The pottery dating in this work is accurate for the most part. The Emergency Survey opened a window to the area on the basis of a dated survey, but the settlement

conclusions are very general and there is no division into landscape units, climate or flora, etc. For example, no division between Mediterranean regions and fringes of the desert exists in their work.

During the 13 years between the Emergency Survey and the beginning of our work in 1980, several visits were made to the area. Ilan (1973, 349-351) visited Kh. Jabaris, Wadi Malih, the Roman road from Shechem to Beth Shean (ibid, 354-356), and the area of Tel el-Far'ah and 'Ain Beidan (ibid, 365-369). Zori (1977) visited several sites in the area of Kh. 'Ibziq.

Excavations:

The primary excavation work in our area, between the years 1946 and 1962, was carried out by a French expedition headed by Father R. De Vaux at Tel el-Far'ah (North – De



1. Two of the first explorers in East Manasseh: H.H. Kitchener of the SWP (left) and Edward Robinson (right).

Vaux and Steve 1947; 1948; 1951; 1952; 1955; 1957; 1961-1962). The excavations shed light on various archaeological and historical problems, and clarified the stratigraphy of the city and regional pottery inventory. They were published as interim reports in the *Revue Biblique* as well as in two final reports: on the Iron Age – Chambon (1984) and on the Middle Bronze Age - Mallet (1987, and see also De Vaux 1992).

Minor excavations were carried

out at Kh. Muqeysimeh (Archaeological News 1973, 11-12) and at Tel Makhruq in 1974. These two excavations were published only in Archaeological News and in various articles (See also Yeivin 1992; Yeivin and Eisenberg 1992). In 1988 the Chalcolithic Period site of 'Ain Hilu was excavated by our team, and the dig continued and was extended by S. Bar in 2006. Table I contains a summary of the previous surveys in comparison to our present survey:

Land- scape unit	of these published already by					
	Sites (Manasseh)	SWP	Porath '68	Emer- gency Survey '72	Newly Found by Us	Percentage of newly found by us from Total
Zebabdeh	23	8	-	6	17	74
Salmeh	21	3	-	3	18	85
Tubas	16	5	-	3	13	81
Malih	34	5	-	5	29	85
Jadir	22	4	-	-	22	100
Buqe'ah	27	10	-	7	20	74
Tammun	5	1	1	-	4	80
Far'ah	47	11	23	6	18	38
Humsah	28	-	-	2	26	93
Desert Fringes	38	1	-	4	34	89
Total and Average	261	48	24	36	201	78

Table 1: Number and percentage of new sites in East Manasseh. The Survey of Manasseh is compared to other modern surveys.

Notes: 1. The same site may have been visited more than once; 2. The number of sites does not include the additions at 'Iraq el-Hamam and Ras Kharubeh.

B. The Geography of East Manasseh

1. *Boundaries of the Region*

This area, encompassing almost 540 sq km, has clear, natural borders in the south and east; in the north and west we relied on the borders of the relief lines (geomorphologic lines) which require an explanation.

The northern border: This border passes along a tributary of Wadi Shubash, beginning its course in Zebabdeh Valley, south of the village of Tilfit. The border between the territory surveyed in the first volume (the Shechem Syncline) and the second volume passes, at its inception, along the road from Zebabdeh to the village of el-Mughair. One km to the east of the place at which the paved road to Kh. Tannin leaves the above road, the border returns to the course of Wadi Shubash. In the east the northern border ends at the place where this wadi exits to the plain of the Beth Shean Valley (Israel Grid 2002/1920), not far from the Qa'un Springs.

The eastern border: This border passes along the line where the mountainous ridges of the Desert Fringes meet the narrow plain of the Jordan Valley. In most places the border passes along the Beth Shean – Jericho road, but an exception is the northern portion of the survey's territory, for about 4 km,

where an 'enclave' near the village Bardaleh entered the area of the Fourth volume. Some of the wadis to the west of the Beth Shean – Jericho road have been left out of the present volume and were included, also, in the next one.

The southern border: This border is based on the most important formation of the area, the geological fault of Wadi Far'ah. The beginning of the borderline, in the east, is at the Jordan River itself, near Jiftliq Junction. From there it passes, along the contour line between Ras el-Kharubeh and the river delta, to the narrow crossing point of Bab en-Naqb. From there the borderline crosses the river southward and crosses the slopes of Jebel Kebir, up to the summit of Sheikh Bilan near Elon Moreh. From there the border turns north and ends at 'Ain Beidan.

The western border: This border is based on the inner, eastern margins of the Shechem Syncline. The line goes along the road from 'Ain Beidan to ez-Zebabdeh (our road B5). This landscape unit includes the villages of Sir, Kfer and ez-Zebabdeh itself, and the border passes along the eastern margins of Sanur Valley. From there it ascends through Kh. 'Anahum and joins up with the northern border near Tilfit.

2. *Geology and Relief*

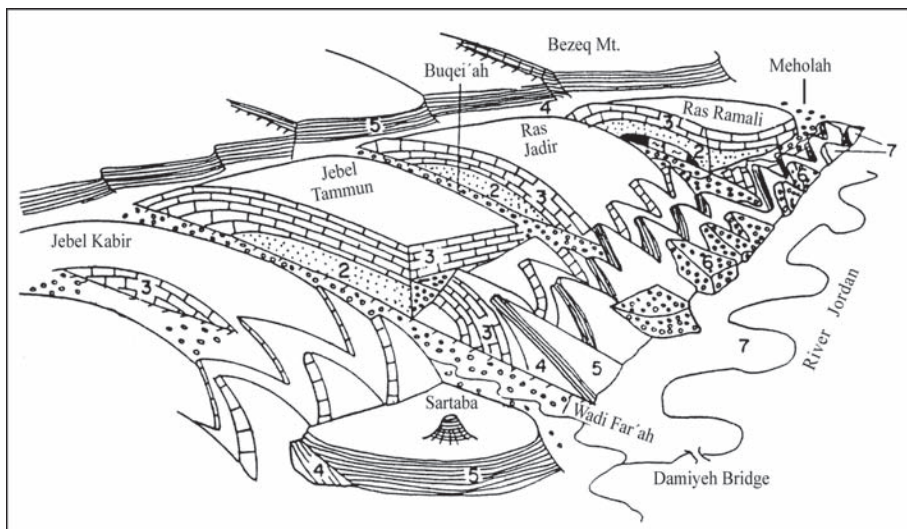
General: The main geomorphologic formation of the area is the Far'ah Anticline, which borders the Shechem Syncline in the east (Cook, Roth and Meimaran 1970; 1980). The anticline is the northern continuation of the chain of anticlines of Judah and Ephraim (Picard and Golani 1965). It contains a broad, subterranean axis, with a relatively narrow upper axis. The slanted blocs of the Far'ah Anticline slope moderately west, while the eastern branch drops sharply toward the Jordan Valley.

The length of the anticline is 30 km, and its width reaches about 15 km. It includes Jebel Kebir, Jebel Tammun, the northern Buqei'ah, Ras Jadir and Ras el-Mubarah.

With the exception of the Buqei'ah, all the blocs slope with their summits facing southwest.

The anticline is broken by faults which created river valleys and wide ravines. The longest of the faults is the valley of Wadi Far'ah. To the north, along the southeast–northwest axis, stretch the Buqei'ah and the valley of Wadi Malih. In all these areas, the soft, unstable rock formations aided the erosive processes.

The special structure created a relatively isolated geomorphologic units in East Manasseh. The absolute elevation of the blocks of the Far'ah Anticline is just 500-800 m a.s.l., but the breaking and transferring processes caused their considerable elevation and strong erosion



2. A tri-dimensional geological section of East Manasseh. The figures are the following groups: 1 – Arad; 2 – Kurnub; 3 – Judah; 4 – Mount Scopus; 5 – Avdat; 6 – Tiberias; 7 – Dead Sea (after Meimaran 1992, 365).

eastward, to the base of erosion of the Jordan Valley. These processes greatly affected the creation of the Desert Fringes.

The fringes of Manasseh, the plateau on the eastern edges of the anticline, form a triangular shape whose southern point is at el-Mahruq near Jiftliq, whose northern point is at the place where Wadi Shubash flows into the Jordan and whose eastern point is north of Sahl Ibziq. This plateau contains four large *grabens* or depressions, which point toward the Jordan Valley. These are the result of faults and folds which fractured the anticline and were later widened by erosion. From north to south are the following recesses: Wadi Shubash, Wadi Malih, the Buqe'ah and Wadi

Far'ah.

3. *The Geology of East Manasseh* (summary of the article by Y. Meimaran 1992)

In East Manasseh an almost entire series of rock units has been exposed, from the Upper Jurassic Period to the present time. The rocks are divided into formations which are divisible into groups. The overall depth of the seven rock groups is more than 2.5 km, and these are the main groups:

Arad group: This group of the Jurassic Period is composed of limestone rocks with a few intermediate layers of Huwwar. Remains of shells and sea urchins indicate shallow sea conditions. The group, 200 m



3. A view to the west, to the Wadi Malih cliffs. The Chalcolithic site of 'Ain Hilu is on the left slope. 1990.

deep, is exposed near Burj el-Malih. The layers are concentrated here in an elevated bloc.

Kurnub group: This group, dated to the lower Cretaceous Period, is composed of sandstone with remains of wood, and chalky sandstone with remains of shells. The wood and sandstone indicate stratification in land conditions, following sea withdrawal at the end of the Jurassic Period. The chalky sandstone is the result of the next step: withdrawal of the sea, with the stratification of the Judah group. The Kurnub group, exposed close to the Arad group near Burj el-Malih, is 200 m deep. Its layers were also detected to the south, at the edges of Jebel Tammun and Jebel Kebir.

Volcanic rocks: The base of the Kurnub group is composed of the special "Taiyasir Volcanics", made of magmatic rocks.

Judah group: Dating to lower Cretaceous-Turonian periods, this group is 1000 m deep and built of carbonate rocks. These consist above all of limestone and Dolomites, with few Huwwars and chalks. These were stratified in a shallow sea. At the base of the group there is a "blanche" limestone cliff, identified in the ranges of Ras Mubarah, Ras Jadir and Jebel Tammun and Jebel Kebir.

Mount Scopus group: This chalky group is dated to the Sennonian-

Paleocene Periods. The microscopic fossils in the chalks indicate a sea hundreds of meters deep. The upper side of the group consists of Taqiyeh formation, whereas its middle is composed of flint layers some centimeters to few meters deep (Meshash formation). The average depth of the group is 300 m, with points where it is only few meters.

The exposures of the group are concentrated along the "seams" between the anticlines and the synclines. These, for instance, are found between the Far'ah Anticline and the Shechem Syncline.

Avdat group: This is dated to the Eocene Period. It is built of limestone and chalk with some quartzite, 350 m deep in East Manasseh to 600 m deep in the Gilboa. Its rocks contain microscopic fossils originating in a shallow sea.

Tiberias and Dead Sea groups: These were stratified in the Neocene-Quaternary Period, when the processes of breaking and folding began. These young groups were stratified in the lower areas of Manasseh. The Tiberias group is based upon a rough conglomerate of pebbles that originated in the Avdat-Kurnub groups, which moved through erosion. On top of it there are sandstone layers replaced by limestone, chalk and gypsum. The overall depth of the Tiberias group is 150 m and it extends along the Desert Fringes.

4. *Climate and Soils*

Of the four climatic types discussed here, three – Mediterranean fringes, semi-arid and tropical (Sudanese-Decanese) – are typical only to East Manasseh. The fourth (Mediterranean) appears in the eastern valleys.

In the eastern valleys and the Far'ah Anticline the climate is Mediterranean (*cf.* Zertal 2004, 26), gradually becoming arid toward the east. East Manasseh is a typical transitional area between the Mediterranean and the arid climates. East of the national watershed, precipitation drops in the direction of the Jordan Valley (Goldreich 1977, 31 and fig. 2). The 600-mm isohete

(average rainfall) on the watershed falls to 300-mm in the Jordan Valley. This drop is gradual, due to the movement eastwards of the rain clouds through the passes of the Far'ah ranges (Goldreich 1977, 30 and fig. 1). The overall result is an average rainfall of 350 mm in East Manasseh.

Droughts are less frequent here than in the fringes of Ephraim and Judah. Like other arid regions, East Manasseh shows a high correlation between climatic and agricultural drought. The rain here is unequally divided over seasons and years (Halpern 1966, 53 *ff.*). This phenomenon finds expression in the Buqei'ah, where unequal rains lead to sowing every other year (oral



4. An air view of Kfer, a small village in the Zebabdeh Valley. Around the place the alluvial plains of the valley are seen. 1993.

communication, Ali Abdallah of Tammun).

The summer in East Manasseh is long and hot, with high temperatures and strong winds along the wadi-valleys. The Sudano-Decanese climate in Wadi Far'ah and (to an extent) Wadi Malih is typified by high temperatures in summer, many hot days and low humidity. The winter is moderate, with low temperatures and few rains. There is also unequal division of rains between the months and the years (Halpern 1966, 51-61).

According to Thorntwhite (Goldreich 1977, 29-33), East Manasseh, Wadi Far'ah and the Jordan Valley all belong to arid region E.

Climatic conditions make agricultural cultivation difficult. Wheat and barley are sown only during rainy years, but even then, no more than 10%-20% of the area is cultivated. This raises the problem of agriculture in periods of prosperity in East Manasseh – MBA II, Iron Age II and Byzantine Period. Could agriculture have been the economic basis of these societies?

The different soils of Manasseh have been reviewed thoroughly in the first volume of the survey (Zertal 2004, 26-27). Here we concentrate upon complementary details relevant to the soils of East Manasseh.

Terra Rossa appears mainly on

the Far'ah range - the upper plateaus of Ras Jadir and Ras es-Salmeh. However, the terra rossa areas here are not consecutive and appear in "patches". This may evolve from the low quantity of precipitations which is involved in the creation of that kind of soil. Terra rossa, together with brown grumosoles, is found also in parts of Wadi Far'ah, the Buqe'ah and the hills around it.

Rendzina soils extend over large parts of the Desert Fringes (Dan 1977, 15): above all in the LU's of Wadi Malih, Ras Jadir and the Desert Fringes. Similar areas are situated near the outlet of Wadi Shubash to the Beth Shean Valley. There, eroded chalky areas are the basis to the rendzina soils. These are dark and light rendzina, which develop upon Nari rocks and are not very fertile.

Brown Mediterranean forest soil is highly typical to East Manasseh. Most of the wide areas from Jebel Tammun to the Buqe'ah and to the Jordan Valley are covered by this soil. Sometimes it is combined with rendzinas. Ravikovitz (1981, 76) claims that the brown soil is created above all in humid climate. Its existence in the arid areas of East Manasseh may indicate extreme rainy conditions in the past.

Eroded alluvial soils (grumosoles) are located in the eastern valleys, the Buqe'ah and the

northwestern part of Wadi Far'ah. These soils are deep, dark and with A-C section. The soils are relatively fertile, but low air capacity makes them suitable mainly for growing cereals. In the valleys of Tubas and Zebabdeh there is a difference between their western and eastern edges. Olives are presently grown in the former, when cereals are sown in the latter. The limit for agriculture in East Manasseh, therefore, is climate and not soils. This, most probably, was the situation in the past, as well.

Colluvial-alluvial soils extend in the wadis and the margins of hills, neighboring the rendzinas and terra rossa areas. Most of them are deep

and dry, but their fertility depends upon their origins and the percentage of organic material.

Stony desert soils (desert lithosoles) are found in the regions close to the Jordan Valley, which typify the eastern parts of East Manasseh and the deltas of the wadis Malih, Far'ah, Shubash and the other small wadis which open to the Jordan Valley. These soils occur in patches and have a high percentage of rocks and stones.

5. Water and Vegetation

The water sources have been generally reviewed in the first volume (Zertal 2004, 27-31); only those in East Manasseh ("the eastern water



5. The delta of Wadi Far'ah, looking south. The dark areas are irrigated soils, a typical phenomenon of the wadi along many periods. In the background the Sartaba hills are seen.

strip”) are discussed here.

The eastern strip contains of the following springs:

1. The Ballatah Springs, no. 100 in the list (*cf.* Zertal 2004, 579-581);

2. ‘Ain Kekub (no. 82 in the general list);

3. ‘Ain Beidan (no. 83 in the list);

4-5. The springs of Dilb and Far‘ah, nos. 84-85 in the list.

The aquifers and aquicluds (water-bearing layers) of the eastern strip are similar to those in the west (Zertal 2004, 28), so that springs evolve from the same geological features. But unlike the western strip, these springs do not continue to northeast, along the “seam” between the Eocene and Sennonian areas. Northeast of ‘Ain Far‘ah there are no more springs, due to the inclination of the geological strata. Under theoretical conditions of more precipitations, more springs along the “seam” can be proposed. This model can probably explain concentrations of sites, above all during the Middle Bronze Age II period.

The few eastern springs are relatively strong, with a high water capacity. The springs of Beidan, Dilb and Far‘ah, all sources feeding Wadi Far‘ah, are among the most powerful in Manasseh. Two other groups of springs are situated near Wadi Far‘ah and Wadi Malih. Near the

springs south of Wadi Far‘ah (Juwar, Dabbur, Za‘anuni, Miski and others) many sites developed, in spite of their low water capacity. In the lower part of Wadi Malih there are several springs (Meiyiteh, Malih and Hilu) near which large sites were developed.

The two following perennial wadis which cross East Manasseh had deep influence on the history of settlement:

Wadi Far‘ah (Nahal *Tirzah*) is the longer and more important one. It is 37 km long, from ‘Ain Far‘ah to the Jordan River near Jisr Damiyeh. Boneh and Baidah (1977, 46) state that its yearly capacity (of the springs Dilb and Far‘ah) was 8.5 millions cubic m. ‘Ain Beidan supplied 4 million more. The small springs south of the wadi do not add much more.

The various characteristics of Wadi Far‘ah – length, moderate slope, stability of stream and fertile soil – made it the richest and best irrigated part of Manasseh. Irrigation is based, today as in the past, upon channels and aqueducts. Information on irrigation here exists from the 18th century onwards. Guérin (original 1875; reprint 1969, 233-243) mentions an “ancient channel that leaves the river”. He describes, “... we crossed an ancient, man-made canal that took its waters from Wadi Far‘ah” (*idem*, 241).

When exactly such irrigation

began is hard to ascertain, but the continuity of settlement in Wadi Far'ah may indicate its long use. The wadi was also an important road, and see below.

Wadi Malih is much shorter than Wadi Far'ah and its water course is rather short. Its overall length is 16 km, of which 10 km bear water. It begins its stream near Burj el-Malih (Israel grid 1943/1923). The Meiyiteh Springs are sweet, but not far from it the salty waters of 'Ain Malih enter the wadi. Ilan (1973, 348) mentions a built aqueduct from 'Ain Meiyiteh to 'Ain Malih, which we were not able to find.

East of the Malih Springs the sweet Hilu Springs are located. Ir-

rigation here was possible in the small valley near Tel el-Hilu (no. 90). It seems that Wadi Malih was used above all to water the herds. Irrigation was negligible, due to the saline water and the small areas of land. Wadi Malih, like Far'ah, was also an important road.

The five vegetation groups of Manasseh, suggested by Zohari (1980, 186-190, and cf. Lipschitz 1987), extend over upon two phytogeographic regions: Mediterranean and Irano-Turannian (arid). Dannin (1970, 5) defines three long strips of vegetation in East Manasseh, with four groups. On the basis of the different scholars' opinions, East Manasseh is divided



6. *Pistacia Atlantica* tree east of Kh. Jabaris. These trees are a rare component in the vegetation of the Desert Fringes.

into the following sections:

A. **The Eastern Valleys** are part of the alluvial valleys' strip. In the first volume of the survey we have suggested (Zertal 2004, 30-31) – following Zohari – that the climax (original plant group) in the valleys was forest park of the Thabor oak. Following the cutting down of the forest to make room for cultivation, a secondary group, typified by *Prosopidion Farcta*, took over the valleys.

B. On the **Far'ah Anticline**, comprising Jebel Kebir, Jebel Tammun, Ras Jadir and Ras Mubarah, there are Mediterranean fringe groups, with forest of carob and Pistacia. These groups stretch on the transitional strips between the Mediterranean and the arid zones, 3 to 15 km wide. Here again, the climax group is the forest park of carob and Pistacia. Among the trees grows yearly vegetation, providing good grazing for herds.

C. East of the anticline (**the Desert Fringes**) is the realm of Irano-Turannian vegetation. Here no trees are found (Sabah 1992, 50), and the only "tree" (or high bush) is the *Sisyphus*. Dannin (1970, 127) claims: "This bush is supposed to be an intruding plant, that has penetrated after the destruction of the original vegetation. In East Manasseh, there is no other tree to be "replaced" by the *Sisyphus*. Therefore we may assume that this bush is original here."

The lack of trees is somehow strange. A yearly average of 350 mm rain can easily be the basis for tree growing, at least in the low areas and the wadis. In the Negev Highlands, for example, trees grow in areas more arid than ours. The complete lack of trees, therefore, needs further exploration.

Traditional agriculture is seasonal and very limited today. No orchards cultivated by the local Arabs were found. However, the new Jewish settlers in the same region (*cf.* the vineyards of Beqa'ot and Ro'i) successfully grow fruit orchards. The finds of our survey indicate olives and grapes which were grown in the past (Iron Age II-III, Byzantine and Early Moslem Periods). The overall picture, though, is of negligence and over-grazing of the region. This process seems to have begun during the Middle Ages.

D. **Wadi Far'ah** is typified by a perennial water supply and high temperatures – a tropical climate. The vegetation here is Sudano-Decanese in type (Zohari 1955, 254; 1980, 187). The groups are governed by the Egyptian *Zaquum*, the *Sisyphus* and the "apple of Sodom". They stretch from the lower parts of the wadis of Far'ah and Malih to the Jordan Valley. Under these conditions, cultivation and irrigation are possible, together with watering of flocks. Agriculture here seems to concentrate on palm orchards and supply green pasture all

year round.

6. *The Roads and Paths (Fig. 8)*

A. Roman and Byzantine Roads

During the survey several Roman roads were recorded; some were already known and others were newly found. "Roman road" is defined as a built road with rim stones. All of them are indicated by the letter *R* and are printed on our map. Here is their list:

R1. The Neapolis - Scythopolis road (our roads B5-B7);

R2. The road from Ma'aleh Shai to the Jordan Valley. This is a built

road running east-west; crossing a moderate plateau north of Wadi Feiran. Its remains have been well preserved near Kh. Suwede (no. 239). The road connects Wadi Fau with B10 – the Jordan Valley road. It may have originated near Kh. Samrah (no. 129);

R3. From Jabaris to Wadi esh-Shaqq. Its remains were found in Kh. Jabaris itself and near Kh. ej-Jadab (no. 72). This seems to be a local road, connecting Jabaris with the Jordan Valley;

R4. From B8 (The Taiyasir – Meholah road) and B7 (Neapolis – Scythopolis) to Kh. Yarzah



7. A built road, presumably Roman (R7), leading to the Buqe'ah along the eastern edges of Tubas Valley.

(no. 106). Its remains are found northwest of the latter;

R5. From Kh. Yarzah southwards to the Buqe'ah. Its remains are beside Wadi Abu 'Ali (grid 190/192) and Ras el-Ahmar (no. 126);

R6. This approaches Jabaris from the southeast, probably beginning near Hamam el-Malih. Its remains are seen near er-Raqqeh (no. 70);

R7. Coming from Taiyasir (begins at R1) and heading southeast, along the western edges of Ras Jadir. This road passes east of Kh. 'Eynun and descends to the Buqe'ah in a difficult pass. In most of its sections it is well preserved;

R8. South of Beqa'ot, between Umm Rkab and EP 170. It seems to have connected Wadi Far'ah and Kh. Humsah (no. 143). Near EP 141 it splits;

R9. Ascends from Kh. Bet Farr to Tel el-Fukhar (no. 176). This road presumably continued eastwards through the *naqb* near Tel Za'anuni (no. 183) and to the valley of Shechem;

R10. From the Buqe'ah to Kh. Yusef and Kh. es-Samrah. Its remains, found near grid 1948/1870, may have connected roads nos. R5 and R2;

R11. Agricultural roads in the fields of Ras Mubarah, 'Iraq el-Hib and Ras el-Badd;

R12. As above, found in the 'Iraq el-Hamam mass.

In addition, the following roads have been positively defined, though their physical remains have not been found:

a. From Shechem to Kh. Farweh (no. 156), and then to the Jordan Valley. This is our B3, whose remains were blurred due to intensive agricultural cultivation;

b. From Beth Shean to Jericho (our B10). Its remains were detected in the southern Beth Shean Valley. According to the milestones found, it was built during Hadrian's reign (Avi Yonah 1966, 91, and Zertal 1992c; 2005, 28-30).

B. Other Ancient Roads and Paths:

East Manasseh was traversed by four national roads, which connected the Shechem Syncline to the Jordan Valley and/or pass along the syncline's edges.

The topography dictated the road lines until the modern era. It seems that most ancient roads, including the Roman ones, ran along the same lines.

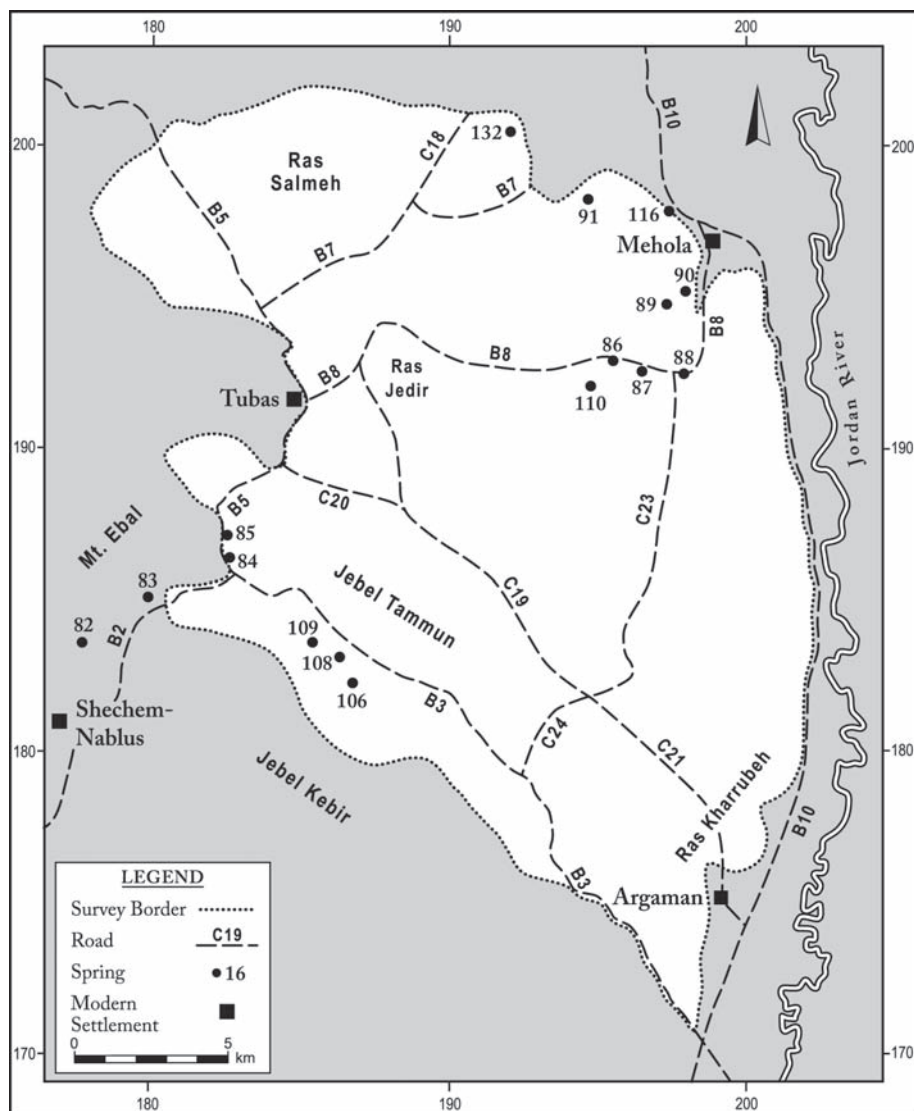
Of the national roads, the following pass through East Manasseh:

1. B2-B3. The Wadi Far'ah road is divided into two parts: B2 – from Shechem to Tel el-Far'ah and B3 – from the latter to Jiftlik. B2 begins in Tel Ballatah (ancient Shechem) and descends along Wadi Abrad to 'Ain

Beidan. Along the road milestones were found, indicating the distances in the Neapolis – Scythopolis road (Thomsen 1917, milestones no. 248-255; Abel 1967, II, 226). The road which succeeded the Roman period might have passed in

a higher level, as indicated by the location of Kh. 'Uqud (site 282 in vol. I, Zertal 2004), where a possible inn stood during the Middle Ages.

At 'Ain Beidan the road splits into two short roads. The first headed



8. The main roads of East Manasseh. B means national road while C – local road. The springs are numbered according to the list in this volume of the survey.

east to Wadi Far'ah and the second north to Tel el-Far'ah. B3 is the Wadi Far'ah road. Today it passes north of the wadi, but according to the SWP map the road passed southwest of the wadi in its lower section, just to cross it near Kh. Basaliyeh (no. 194). It is hard to guess precisely where the road passed in ancient times.

B3 is identified with the "road where the sun goes down" in Deuteronomy 11:30 (*cf.* discussion in Zertal 1988, 316; 1991).

2. B5. From Tel el-Far'ah to the Qabatiyeh junction. This is the eastern parallel to B4 of the first volume. It begins at Tel el-Far'ah and heads north toward Tubas. From there, and through Kh. Fuqahah (no. 47), Kfer and Zebabdeh (nos. 15, 6), it reaches the Qabatiyeh junction. The modern road along the same line crosses the narrow pass beside Kh. 'Anahum, a pass which tends to be flooded in rainy years. Ancient B5 apparently climbed here toward the east to connect to B6, which sets out to the Jezreel Valley.

3. B7, from Kh. Salhab to Beth Shean. It leaves B5 between Fuqahah and 'Aqaba (no. 22). From there, heading northeast, it comes to the *Bezeq* pass, with the two Kh. Ibziq sites (nos. 42, 44) located beside the road. From there, it crossed Sahl Ibziq and turned toward Wadi Khashneh and the Beth Shean Valley. The Roman road here passed directly from Tubas to Taiyasir.

From there to the *Bezeq* pass it is marked C18. Upon reaching Beth Shean it passed near Kh. Qa'un (site no. 3 in the fourth volume of the survey, Zertal 2005). Along B7 several milestones were found; the road was already recorded by the SWP.

4. B8 is the road along Wadi Malih. It leaves B5 at Tubas and heads east toward upper Wadi Malih, called here Wadi el-Hari or, by the SWP, Wadi Sufi el-Khureibat. Then it connects to Wadi Malih near Burj el-Malih. Later on, it leaves the wadi and goes to the fortress at Kh. Umm Ghazal (no. 82) and then to the Jordan Valley.

Of the local roads, the following were added here:

C10 – Meithalun – Kfer: It crosses the Sanur Valley and connects to B5 at Kfer;

C18 – Taiyasir – Kh. Ibziq connects B5 and B7. Here, the remains of the Roman road are clearly visible;

C19 – Taiyasir – the Buqei'ah junction: It leaves Taiyasir along the eastern edges of Tubas Valley. Then it descends to the Buqei'ah and connects to

C20 – Tammun junction – Beqa'ot junction: This road leaves B5 at grid 1845/1905 and moves eastwards to the Buqei'ah. Most of the road is now asphalted, and passes near Kh. 'Atuf (no. 131) to connect to C23 near Kh. Sefireh

(no. 132).

C21 – Buqei'ah junction – Argaman: It crosses the Buqei'ah parallel to C20. After connecting to C23 beside Kh. Umm Qatan it reaches Umm Haraz and descends to the Jordan Valley. This descent is either through Naqb el-Matar (no. 222) or Naqb Umm Khubeza. In both cases it must have reached the valley west of Argaman and, from there, to B10.

C23 – Wadi Far'ah – Tel el-Hilu: This road passes along the modern "Alon road". Then it leaves B3 beside Tel Abu Rumh (no. 190) and ascends to the Buqei'ah to Kh. Muqeysimah. Then it continues northeast to Umm Qatan (no. 133), Kh. Samrah and Wadi Fau. In the PEF map it is indicated "Ancient Road".

C24 – A short branch connecting the eastern Buqei'ah beside Umm Hajar (no. 212), through the Mu-taqallabat valley to Wadi Far'ah.

C. The Landscape Units

(Fig. 9)

In accordance with the principles discussed in the first volume (Zertal 2004, 13-14) East Manasseh was divided into ten landscape units. This division is based on the geomorphology and the history of the area. The order of the units, like order of sites, is from north to south and from west to east.

The landscape units will be dis-

cussed according to two characteristics: their natural data and the settlement type. The first characteristic will be mentioned briefly. In the second section a settlement analysis by periods is presented. In addition, a discussion by periods is found in the recent chapter, section F. We recommend reading this section as a complementary part.

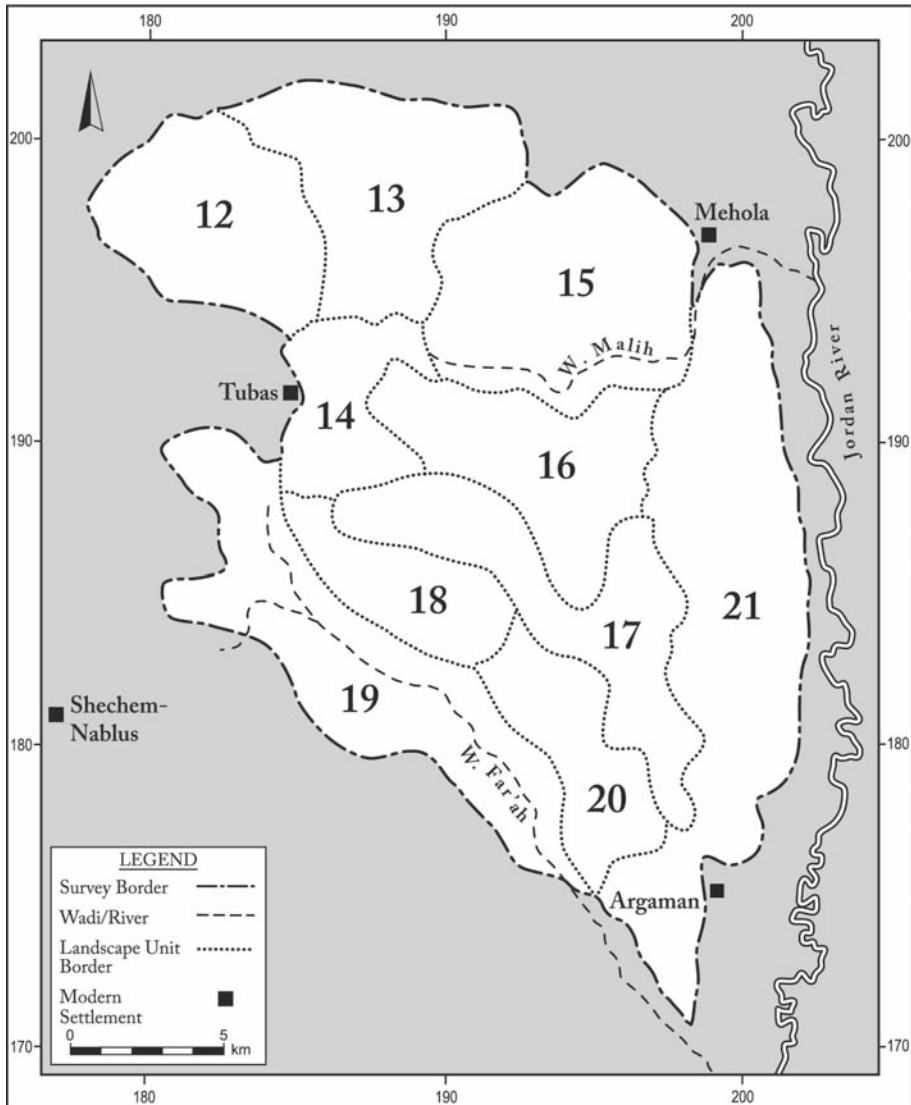
The numbering of the landscape units continues from the first volume. In order to find one's way around, the reader may refer for aid to the borders of the landscape units in figure 9 as well as the attached map of the survey.

12. Zebabdeh Valley

The Zebabdeh Valley covers about 40 sq. km. The valley is, geographically, a highly heterogeneous geographical unit, difficult to clearly determine its natural boundaries. In the north the unit's boundary passes over the Dhahret Tawileh Range, and then to the north of Kh. 'Anahum. From there it turns west to the rocky hills and passes over the upper edge of Sanur Valley, so that the small valley of Sahl Fuheis north of Sir is also included. The southern border passes over the northern edge of Ras el-Aqra' to the village of 'Aqabah, and from there continues along road B5 until Israel Grid 1845/1933. From there it turns east and connects with Landscape Unit no. 13 (Ras es-Salmeh) west of Taiyasir.

Zebabdeh Valley is bordered in the east by the ranges of Ras es-Salmeh and Ras Mubarah (the Far'ah Anticline) and in the west by the eastern edge of Sanur Valley. Its northern part is an easily cultivatable plain, while in the south Wadi Suwed and its tributaries create an

area of low hills. In the western part of the valley is a range (the Zebabdeh Hills), with a small valley (Sahl Fuheis) to its west. The central part of Zebabdeh Valley is covered with deep alluvial soil, which makes it a fertile agricultural region where mostly field crops are grown. In the



9. Map of the landscape units of East Manasseh with their numbers.

western part, near the village of Zebabdeh, olive trees are cultivated. The ranges to the east of the valley, on which Mediterranean fringe undergrowth grows, are used primarily for grazing; apparently this was so in the past as well.

Today the valley lacks sources of flowing water, but the discovery of Chalcolithic Period sites and the fact that the unit is on the "seam" between the Shechem Syncline and the area to its east, indicates that in the past there were springs there. In the western edge of the valley an important road (B5) runs lengthwise, while the Shechem – Beth Shean road (B7) crosses the southern edge.

Twenty three sites were found in the valley, at a density of 1.73 sq km per site. Both Mediterranean and arid elements are expressed in the valley. To the north are two Chalcolithic Period settlements, which were possibly based upon grazing. During the Early Bronze Age the valley was virtually uninhabited, while during Middle Bronze Age I and II it comprised an important center. Five sites of the former were discovered, including a very large one (Khallet Taleb, no. 11)¹, next to which was an enclosure (er-Rahweh – no. 7), whose function was possibly cultic. The settlements are scattered in a strip like shape along the edge of the valley. Six settle-

ments from Middle Bronze Age II are recorded, some developed into tells (Tilfit, Safiriyan, Zebabdeh and others). Between the two Middle Bronze Ages there is continuity of about 30%, while in the Late Bronze Age only one site remained, highly important (Sheikh Safiriyan – no. 2). During Iron Age I there were four settlements in the valley.

As in the other eastern valleys, this unit saw a transition from nomadism (Iron Age I, 13th–12th centuries BCE) in the Desert Fringe to later, permanent settlement in the Mediterranean regions. The valley was presumably been the area of the No'ah clan of the Manasseh families (Joshua 17:3-7). This clan is mentioned in the Samaria Ostraca, but only a few shipments of olive oil were recorded from there (*cf.* Zertal 1996a; for Samaria Ostraca see Noth 1932; Mazar 1960; Rainey 1962; Yadin 1959; 1968; Lemaire 1977, 23-85). The eight Iron Age II sites are relatively large in area; in three of them bowls with wedge decoration were recorded, evidence of a settlement also during Iron Age III and possibly of Cuthaeen communities. The eight sites of the Persian Period belong to the Mediterranean areas. During the later periods (Roman-Byzantine Periods, Early Moslem and Medieval Periods) there were many settlements in the valley (10-12 per period). The settlements here tends to have a "Mediterranean" character, and

1 All along this text numbers of sites indicate similar numbers in the book.

the Salmeh Range may have served as a “barrier” to the desert fringe to its east.

13. Ras es-Salmeh

Ras es-Salmeh connects the eastern valleys with Beth Shean Valley. It is constructed, in its western part, of a high range of mountains. To its east is a wide expanse of hills descending to the south of the Beth Shean Valley and to the Jordan Valley. The length of this landscape unit, from west to east, is 8 km. Its breadth, from north to south, is about 5 km and its area is about 40 sq. km. This unit contains natural boundaries: in the north the deep channel of Wadi Shubash; to the east the bor-

der passes along the line between the desert fringe and the Bardaleh Hills (the southern part of the Beth Shean Valley); in the south it passes along Wadi Khashneh which originates near the village of Taiyasir and which spills into the Jordan Valley, and in the west it passes along the eastern edge of Zebabdeh Valley.

The range of Ras es-Salmeh belongs to the Far‘ah Anticline. It includes three summits, the highest of which is Ras es-Salmeh itself (713 m a.s.l.). To the north of the range is an area of low hills, in which Wadi Shubash begins its journey. The area to the east of Ras es-Salmeh is composed of three mountainous blocs, high and isolated from each other by deep wadis: E.P. 506, E.P.



10. View to the northeast toward *Bezeq* Valley (Sahl ‘Ibziq). Mediterranean fringe undergrowth grows on the ranges surrounding the valley.

556 and 'Iraq el-Hamam. The wadis of Khashneh and Sherifeh and their tributaries separate the blocs and served as ancient passageways. East of Ras es-Salmehi is the small Sahl Ibziq, whose area is 1 sq. km and which serves as a crossroads.

Most of unit no. 13 is composed of limestone rock of Avdat formation. The soil is terra rossa with complexes of rendzinas and grumosoles in Sahl Ibziq and in the wadis. On the ranges grow Mediterranean fringe botanical groups, such as carob trees, terebinth and pistacia. The annual shrubbery is abundant in winter, and the area is suitable for grazing, although it contains no water sources. The steep topography makes passage difficult, but an important road from Shechem-Nablus to Beth Shean passed through Wadi Khashneh, the fortress at el-Quleh (no. 43) having protected that road.

This area is poor in sites, both today and in ancient times. Out of the 27 sites discovered (including the farms at 'Iraq el-Hamam) there are virtually no tells; the settlement is composed of small farms or single-period settlements. The average characteristics for the area are long distances from water sources and from agricultural land, and steep topography. There was a certain prosperity during the Chalcolithic Period (four sites along Wadi Shubash), but during the rest of the Bronze and Iron Ages

the region was almost uninhabited. Beginning in the Late Roman Period farms were set up in the area, and even a central site (Kh. Ibziq [nos. 42, 44], founded during the Iron Age but more active during the later periods), which owes its existence to the main road nearby. A relative increase in the number of sites continued during the Byzantine and Early Moslem Periods, but declined afterwards. With the exception of Rabbah (no. 34), the area is lacking in Arab villages, and most of the settlement there today is of Bedouins.

Ras es-Salmeh contains an exceptional wealth of remains of ancient agriculture from the Late Roman and Byzantine periods; these include not only hewn installations, roads and terraces, but also small farms and a type of "centers" for processing products. The concentration of sites is notable on the large range of 'Iraq el-Hamam, where at least 13 such places were recorded. It can be viewed as an agricultural "hinterland" region, with both grazing and orchards, filled up with settlements using the reserves of soil needed for the centers around it.

14. Tubas Valley

This is the southernmost of the eastern valleys; its name comes from the large village on its western edge. Tubas Valley is a small, enclosed unit, about 20 sq. km in

area. It is bordered in the north by the Tawileh Range (a topographical step between it and Zebabdeh Valley), in the east by the high Ras Jadir, in the south by the 'Asharin Ranges and in the west by the Mafqa'ah Plateau above the village of Tubas.

The valley is a plain rising from west to east, toward the steep range of Ras Jadir. Its western part is ensconced in the Sennonian belt in the eastern edge of the anticline; no water sources are found there. Aside from the valley itself, included in this unit are the low ranges of 'Eynun and 'Asharin to its south, and those of Miqwaq and Tawileh to its north. The soil is fertile alluvium (grumosole), composed of complexes of Mediterranean brown forest soil and rendzina, which drains to the southwest through Wadi Sabun. The two important roads of the valley are B5 (Tel el-Far'ah – Qabatiyeh junction), which crosses the western edge of the valley, and B8, which departs from the former westward towards Taiyasir and Wadi Malih. Another road (C19) leads to the Buqei'ah along the western edge of Ras Jadir. The fact that the valley is an important crossroads influenced the settlement in the region during all the periods.

The 17 sites of the valley (an average of one site for every 1.25 sq. km) comprised a rich complex, especially in the Middle Bronze Age II and the Iron Age. Among the

sites are two large tells (Kh. Fuqahah and Kh. 'Eynun), one small tell (ej-Jelameh) and single- and multi-period ruins. The density of settlement is also emphasized because the central sites are located along the edge of the valley, with an average area of 9.6 dunams (2.4 acres) per site. The Early Bronze Age sites, whose general dependency on water sources is about 90% (i.e. 90% of the sites are located upon water), are entirely missing from this landscape unit; but there is one Chalcolithic Period site. The nine sites from the Middle Bronze Age II (56% of the total!) comprise an exceptional concentration. Among them there are no tells, but rather "strip sites" along the valley edge, large and small unfortified sites and enclosures. These are mostly single-period, rural settlements, with homogenous pottery. In the past we raised the hypothesis of the existence of a strip of springs along the edges of the syncline under somewhat rainier conditions (Zertal 1988, 180-185). This theory could explain the wealth of settlement.

Two of the Middle Bronze Age II settlements continued into the Late Bronze Age, and then there is an increase in settlement in the Early Iron Age. Of the seven sites from this period (43% of the total), three are situated upon an ancient, Middle Bronze Age site, while the other four were founded on virgin soil; among them are the two important

tells of the valley. The area apparently served as a political and settlement center during that period. It is connected with Shechem and its region, as also emerges from the repetitive stories of Abimelech (*Thebez*; see chapter three for identifications and also historical survey). Archaeologically, the valley played a role in the early stage of the Israelite settlement, the transition from semi-nomadism to permanent settlement. The wealth of sites during the Iron Age possibly stems from the fact that the valley is the link between Wadi Far'ah which was the principal "entry conduit" of the Israelite tribes, and Wadi Malih, the secondary "entry conduit". During Iron Age II a decrease is discernable (only three settlements), with an increase during the Byzantine and Early Moslem Periods. Apparently the village Tubas (known as *Thopas* during the Middle Ages) took over from *Thebez* as the most important city in the valley, from the Early Roman Period onwards. This phenomenon of "changeover" of leading cities is known in other areas as well.

15. Wadi Malih

The focus here is the wadi and the areas adjacent to it, with an extensive area of the hilly desert fringe and the hills to its north. The unit is about 10 km long (east-west) and 6 km wide on the average (north-south); its area is about 60 sq km.

The border in the north and northwest is Wadi Khashneh, running from Taiyasir to Bardaleh; in the east the border runs along the line between the Desert Fringes and the Jordan Valley, from Wadi Malih to the outlet of Wadi Khashneh. In the south the border runs along the line of ranges south of Wadi Malih, while in the west the village of Taiyasir serves as the border. This landscape unit is comprised of two parts:

a. Wadi Malih itself, a very narrow strip around the channel. In the upper part it includes the small plain east of Taiyasir; from there it descends in a moderate slope of Wadi el-Heri until it reaches to the high point with the fortress of Burj el-Malih. Here, the wadi crosses a narrow bloc of hard rock (between the hill of the fortress and E.P. 174), and continues its way east, in a valley surrounded by cliffs, until Tel el-Hilu. Adjacent to this tell, at Israel grid 1982/1925, the wadi turns sharply east again and exits into the Jordan Valley.

The main settlement here was concentrated in the channel of Wadi Malih and its springs.

b. The hilly area to the north of Wadi Malih is based, like Ras es-Salmeh, on several blocs from which long slopes descend eastward to the Jordan Valley. Their peaks are Ras el-Badd (571 m a.s.l., hereafter a.s.l.), 'Iraq el-Mubarah (551 m) in the west, Ras Ramali (419 m)

and Ras Abu Shusheh (222 m) in the southwest. These blocs are con-

structed of ancient rock from the Lower Cretaceous (Kurnub group)



11. View westward to the canyon of Wadi esh-Shaqq, near its outlet to the Jordan Valley. Similar places mark the transition from the Manasseh Fringes to the Jordan Valley.

and upon it, respectively, limestone from the Judah group. Near Ras Ramali there is an enclave of volcanic rocks. The entire area drains eastward in long wadis (Salmeh, Hamad, el-Lathm, Khallet el-Badd, Mhallal and esh-Shaqq).

The soil in this region includes complexes of rendzina and brown forest soil, with pockets of brown basaltic soils. North of Wadi Malih the soil is very shallow and eroded, yet in several plateaus fertile soil is found (the neighborhoods of Kh. Mhallal [no. 78] and 'Iraq ej-Jadab [no. 72]). Vegetation is composed of Mediterranean shrubs with few trees (in particular carobs, and sometimes Israeli terebinth trees) and many species of perennial and annual bushes (desert broom group and others). The remains of orchard agriculture suggest intensive cultivation during the Roman-Byzantine Periods and perhaps previously.

Except for the important road in Wadi Malih (B8), few real paths passed through the northern area.

In this unit 34 sites were found (1.76 sq. km per site), a figure that can be misleading, since it concerns mainly tiny sites. Three groups of sites are discerned, to be discussed separately: Wadi Malih itself, the eastern edges and the hilly area.

The Wadi Malih group encompasses 12 sites, the majority of which (eight) are centered densely

along the lower part of the river, near the springs. The three sites to the east of Taiyasir are an extension of Tubas Valley (two of them were established during Middle Bronze Age II). Next to 'Ain el-Meiyiteh are two large sites from Middle Bronze Age I (el-Bird [no. 91] and Kh. el-Meiyiteh [no. 90]). Upon the former are a site from Middle Bronze Age II and a fortress (?) from Iron Age I-II. The two multi period tells in the area are Kh. Mhallal and the small Tel el-Hilu (no. 96).

The eastern edge group includes 14 sites, adjacent to the Jordan Valley. The major concentration here is the settlements of esh-Shaqq Valley, containing eight sites. They consist of sites from the Chalcolithic Period to the Early Moslem Period, based on the abundance of water, the road and the soil in the small valley.

The fortresses along the road deserve special mention. Among these are the Middle Bronze Age site at Jebel Khimyar (no. 74), the fortress at el-Bird (no. 91), the two Iron Age fortresses in esh-Shaqq Valley (nos. 81 and 83) and the Crusader/Moslem fortress at Burj el-Malih (no. 89). This concentration is somewhat unusual, and indicates the importance of the road and the sensitivity of passage at the lower Wadi Malih.

The third group, the hilly area, encompasses eight sites. With the exception of the two large ones

(Kh. Mhallal and Kh. Jabaris), the rest are farms or solitary structures, primarily from the Late Roman, Byzantine and Early Moslem Periods. Kh. Mhallal is a tell founded during Middle Bronze Age I-II and flourished during Iron Age I. It can be assumed that the place was functioning, during the Iron Age, as a central site north of Wadi Malih; this position later passed to Kh. Jabaris (no. 69), a large ruin on a mountain in the center of the area. It appears that this unit served as an agricultural hinterland for the settlements in Wadi Malih and the Jordan Valley; computer data indicate approximately a 15% correlation to water, agricultural soil

and roads. The region was "filled" with farms during the Late Roman Period, when the overpopulation pushed the farmers to the less fertile areas.

16. Ras Jadir

The unit of Ras Jadir "paralleling" in the south to that of Wadi Malih; it is located between the above and the Buqei'ah, and is similar in character to that of Ras es-Salmeh. It also includes a high range in the west and a hilly area in the east, and descends slowly toward the Jordan Valley. The unit is 10 km long, 5 km wide on the average, and 49 sq km in area. The shape of the area is trapezoidal, with its apex being



12. Flocks of sheep on the heights of Ras Jadir. Annual, exceptionally rich pastureland characterizes the transitional ranges between the Mediterranean region and the prairie, which served as pasture areas during all the periods.

Taiyasir in the northwest and Kh. Umm el-Qatan (no. 133) in the southeast. It has natural boundaries: Wadi Malih in the north, the deep rift of Wadi el-Fau (with road C23) in the east, Tubas Valley in the west and the Buqe'ah in the south.

The length of Ras Jadir range (part of Far'ah Anticline, 712 m a.s.l.) is about 5 km. This is a slanted bloc whose slopes are particularly steep and which has a thin "backbone" along the peak. This topography dictates the lack of settlement, while long ranges descend from Ras Jadir eastward. These are moderate extensions with wadis and small valleys between them: the wadis Abu 'Ali, Khallet el-Asmar, Khallet esh-Shardeh and others. West of the geological fault extends another range – Umm 'Uqbeh, descending by steep slopes to Wadi el-Fau.

As with the other parts of the Far'ah Anticline, the Ras Jadir unit is composed of marine limestone from the Mount Scopus and Judah groups. Terra rossa soil and shrubby flora of the Mediterranean fringes are found on the range. The eastern slopes are covered with mountainous rendzina, brown forest soil and complexes of the two. The range of Umm 'Uqbeh is composed of ancient rock from the Lower Cretaceous Period (Avdat Group). The shrubby vegetation prevalent on Ras Jadir, rapidly becomes sparse, being replaced by low vegetation (with the group of desert broom) in

the east.

Moderate topography east of Ras Jadir made transport easy, with Roman roads as evidence. Between the important roads of Wadi Malih and the Buqe'ah two connecting roads are recorded: one east of Burj el-Malih and the other in Wadi el-Fau (C23). The entire area is lacking in water sources; however, proximity to Wadi Malih was an assisting factor in the settlement during the various periods.

The 22 sites here (2.2 sq. km for each site) can be categorized as follows: two multi period tells; two small towns from the Roman-Byzantine Periods; and the rest are small, mostly single-period sites. The tells are Kh. Yarzah (B – no. 104) in the foothills of Ras Jadir, and Kh. Yusef (no. 117) at the edge of the Buqe'ah. The settlements concentration in the vicinity of Yarzah can possibly be explained by the water sources. We assume that it was a central place in the region, in the Bronze and Iron Ages, and perhaps afterwards as well. During Middle Bronze Age II settlement flourished in Ras Jadir (ten settlements, about 50% of all the sites!), and also during Iron Age I-II (seven sites in each). The next "wave" was during the Byzantine period (seven sites); settlement in the region practically ended after this.

The second multi period site, Kh. Yusef, was settled from the Chalcolithic Period until the Iron Age.

This is a large, important site, with settlement primarily during Middle Bronze Age I, and seems to have been connected to the Buqe'ah. The small sites are extended farms or small villages, both prospered during Middle Bronze Age II and the Iron Age. They were based upon a combination of pasture and orchard agriculture. Evidence for the latter are the agricultural installations. Middle Bronze Age I settlements, found in the adjacent areas (Wadi Malih and the Buqe'ah) are missing here.

Of the settlement factors, the roads are a possible characteristic in this unit. No fewer than 12 out of 22 sites are located on important

roads in all the periods. The influence of water, soil and topography is less significant.

During the later periods (Roman-Byzantine Periods and later) there are two small towns in the region (Kh. Yarzah (A – no. 106) and Kh. Umm el-'Uqbeh (B – no. 100), built on the regular model of the period: central settlements surrounded by farms. It is unclear why the region was empty of sites during the later periods (Early Moslem onwards).

The uniqueness of Ras Jadir, in summary, is due to two phenomena: flourishing of settlement during Middle Bronze Age II and Iron age I-II, and the high correlation



13. Lunch break of the surveying team in the desert fringe. Lacking a natural source of shade, we improvised, as the photo shows.

between the two (as in Tubas Valley) and its emptiness following the Byzantine Period.

17. The Buqeī'ah

This region, also called the "Northern Buqeī'ah" (as opposed to the southern Buqeī'ah in the Judaean Desert), is a large *graben* (a geomorphic depression) oriented from northwest to southeast; it runs parallel to the *grabens* of the Wadis Malih and Far'ah and lies between the two. It is about 15 km long and 3 km wide on the average; together with its edges it reaches an area of about 55 sq. km.

The Buqeī'ah has natural boundaries: in the northwest the border extends from the village of Tammun to Ras Jadir; in the northeast its border is from the high fringes of the Buqeī'ah along the ranges of el-Mubarah, Ras esh-Sheikh Saleh and Ras Umm Hasan. In the area of Twel edh-Dhiyab the boundary turns north to include in the Buqeī'ah the extension of the valley in which Kh. as-Samrah (no. 129), the settlement of Ro'i and the sites in their vicinity are located. In the southeast the Buqeī'ah narrows and borders, in the Desert Fringes unit, near Kh. Umm Kharaz (no. 144). Its southwestern border passes along the prominent edges of Ras Humsah and Jebel Tammun.

The Buqeī'ah is an undulating plain that gently slants from the

area of Tammun (320 m a.s.l.) to Umm Kharaz (sea level), and drains into the Jordan Valley via Wadi Durah. The entire series of sedimentary rocks, from the lower Cretaceous to the Senonian, crosses the Buqeī'ah. It is covered with fertile alluvial soil with complexes of other soils, and comprises a sort of "granary" of East Manasseh. During rainy years, good grain crops grow, but the land is utilized mainly for grazing, which supports large flocks of sheep to this day.

The Buqeī'ah and its fringes lack water sources, but the area is not far from flowing rivers: the wadis Far'ah and Malih. Being convenient for passage, it was crossed latitudinally by road C23 (the contemporary "Alon Road") which connected the wadis Far'ah and Malih, and longitudinally by roads C20-21 which connected Tubas Valley and the Jordan Valley.

The considerable ecological agricultural advantage of the Buqeī'ah is its fertile plains. The 26 sites in it (about 2 sq. km per site in average) are arranged in relative density on the fringes, and an analysis of the settlements indicates certain distinctive characteristics of this landscape unit.

Three settlement "waves" characterize the Buqeī'ah: Middle Bronze Age I, Iron Age II and the later periods (Byzantine-Early Moslem-Medieval). Absent are sites from Middle Bronze Age II and Iron Age

I (the Israelite settlement period). From Middle Bronze Age I seven sites were found (26% of the total), of which five are concentrated densely at the western tip of the Buqei'ah and one is found on the northern extension (the enclosure of es-Samrah [no. 128]), to which the large Kh. Yusef (no. 117) should be added. The sites of this period are unfortified and have scattered structures and large quantities of potsherds. A wall of big stones surrounds the single enclosure that was found. The sites of the period are related to soil (as with other periods in the Buqei'ah), and it can be assumed that this unit was an important center for sheep grazing, as it is today (the semi-nomadic population makes up the overwhelming majority of the inhabitants). Also prominent is the "cluster model" in which the sites are arranged, as well as the fact that the adjacent areas, Ras Jadir and Ras Humsah, lack sites from Middle Bronze Age I.

The lack of Iron Age I settlements in the Buqei'ah is difficult to explain, since most of the favorable conditions existed here, and it may be that unknown human factors were at play here. The second period of prosperity (Iron Age II with its ten sites, 37% of the total) is characterized by a multitude of small farms at the edges of the Buqei'ah and the absence of large sites. Here, too, the correlation to soil is prominent, and it seems that the econ-

omy was based mainly on grazing and farming of grains. The largest farm (Kh. Musheibik, no. 127) is situated in the hilly area at the high edges of the Buqei'ah and does not make use of plains for grazing and farming. Also worthy of note is the fortress (?) at Kh. Umm Qatan (no. 133), which was evidently intended to guard the crossroads and fields of the Buqei'ah. From the fact that five sites continued their existence into Iron Age III, it can possibly be concluded that the Iron Age farming in the Buqei'ah was founded at a late stage of Iron Age II (from the end of the 8th century to the 7th century BCE).

During the third, later periods of prosperity (Byzantine Period – 16 sites; Early Moslem Period – 20 sites; Medieval – 12 sites), the region achieved full realization of its economic possibilities. Aside from farms, agricultural courtyards and seasonal structures, relatively large settlements also appeared (Kh. es-Samrah [no. 129], Kh. Muqeysimeh [no. 140] and Kh. 'Atuf [no. 131]); it may be assumed that in this period cultivation of orchards began, which made possible a growth in population. Worthy of note are the two courtyard fortresses of the *castellum* type (Kh. Humsah [no. 143] and Kh. Umm Kharaz [no. 144]), which were established during the Late Roman Period and protected the important roads descending into the Jordan Valley and Wadi

Far'ah. During and after the Byzantine Period, settlement diminished somewhat; the threshing floors in the farms provide additional evidence of the importance of grain growing in this unit.

18. Jebel Tammun

Jebel Tammun is a small, enclosed landscape unit, well bordered on all sides. It encompasses only the Jebel Tammun range itself, 9 km long and an average of 2 km in width, and is about 18 sq. km in area. This is one of the panhandles of the Far'ah Anticline, oriented northwest – southeast, parallel to the Buqei'ah in the north and Wadi Far'ah in the south.

Jebel Tammun is a high, raised, sloping range; at its highest summit it reaches an altitude of 590 m a.s.l., towering 500 m over Wadi Far'ah and 450 m over the Buqei'ah. It is composed of Judah group limestone, lacks any water sources, and no roads cross it due to its steepness. The areas suitable for settlement are the narrow strip along the summit, 100-200 m wide, and the northeast shoulder. Jebel Tammun is bordered on the north by the Buqei'ah and in the south by Wadi Far'ah; in the west it is bounded by a path near el-Ajjam (no. 146) and in the east by an ancient road that descends from the Buqei'ah to Wadi Far'ah through Bab en-Naqb.



14. A prominent enclosure (el-Ajjam) from the MBA I on a rocky hill on the western slopes of Jebel Tammun. These enclosures denote the concentration of settlements of this period in several places in the survey area.

Only five sites have been discovered in the entire Jebel Tamnun unit (3.6 sq. km. per site) and just one of them is a settlement (a farm), while the others are "special sites" whose character is difficult to determine. The farm (Umm el-Kubesh, no. 149) is situated on the northeast shoulder, in a place where a small plateau has 200-300 dunams (50-75 acres) of cultivable land. The other sites include two enclosures (Abu Loz [no. 145] and el-'Ajjam [no. 146]). The former, on a summit, is apparently connected with a complex of Far'ah sites and has quite a bit of ceramics from the Chalcolithic Period and Middle Bronze Age; the latter is an enclosure of large stones on a high, rocky summit, which possibly served as a center for Middle Bronze Age I sites in the vicinity. The other two sites apparently had a special function: the site of el-Khelayel (no. 148) includes a pile of ash, dust and broken bones and various structures. In a moldy grave a *tumulus* was found, and it may be posited that the whole mountain served, in ancient times, as a holy place, possibly connected with the cemeteries and various ritual functions that apparently took place nearby along Wadi Far'ah.

19. Wadi Far'ah

This landscape unit is the richest in settlements in East Manasseh. It is a long, wide valley with a flowing

river, an important road and much land. Wadi Far'ah thus differs from the other units, and comprises a link between the Mediterranean zone and the Jordan Valley, and between western and eastern Palestine.

The valley of Wadi Far'ah is a geological fault that has widened with erosion, and fertile grumosoles have formed in layers on its "shoulders". The area of the unit is 60 sq. km, and it contains a number of sub-units. In the northwest it encompasses the valley of Tel el-Far'ah itself, with its sites and springs; there, a section of the valley that comes from 'Ain Beidan connects to the channel of wadi Far'ah. In the southwest the border of the unit passes along the steps of Jebel Kebir, which was a settlement center together with its steps.

Forty-seven sites have been found within the unit of Wadi Far'ah (1.2 sq. km per site), and most of them are concentrated close to the edges of the river valley. The sites' characteristics differ slightly from those that we have seen in other landscape units: the sites are larger, the tells are multi-strata and all the periods are represented, primarily the more ancient ones.

Although the prehistoric survey was partial, it appears that the density of prehistoric sites here is significant. Five sites from the Pottery Neolithic Period, almost all continuing into the Chalcolithic Period, were found in Wadi Far'ah.

The eight Chalcolithic Period presences were found mostly within multi period sites. The places from this period lacked any architecture, as opposed to the “enclosures” sites found in other landscape units. The “Far’ah Family” of pottery has already been mentioned, and a continuity of 80% between Neolithic, Chalcolithic and Early Bronze Age I is to be noted. The Early Bronze Age I appears virtually only in this unit, and is absent from the other units. The 19 sites from this period (40% of the total) create a Mediterranean “enclave” which emphasizes the close correlation between the sites and their water sources. The fortified tells from Early Bronze Age II appear only here within East Manasseh (Tel el-Far’ah [no. 151], er-Rjjum [no. 187], Tel Za’anuni [no. 183], Tel Shibli [no. 180] and others). Several principal cemeteries are to be noted, which are situated on the edges of the river valley. This unit was a central cemetery throughout long periods, somewhat similar to Bab edh-Dhra’ in Transjordan.

Middle Bronze Age I sites are relatively rare: unlike the concentrations in nearby regions (*e.g.*, the Buqe’ah), there are only six such sites here. Of the ten Middle Bronze Age II sites, there are single-period tells and villages (Wa’ar el-Quf [no. 159], ‘Ain Dabbur [no. 184], etc.), and there is a continuity of 50% to Late Bronze Age, an unusual phe-

nomenon when considering the sharp decline in settlement during this period. The number of Iron Age I sites (12) rises, representing an important stage in the settlement of the Israelite tribes (end of the 13th century and beginning of the 12th century BCE). The enclosure of el-‘Unuq (a *gilgal* – no. 160) is one of a group of similar enclosures in the Jordan Valley.

During the Iron Age II there was an increase in the number and size of sites. The settlement reached a peak with 15 sites, of which five were tells. Apparently the fortified cities at the western entrance to Wadi Far’ah and its outlet at Tel Simadi indicate the importance of the main road and the connection with Transjordan. Several fortresses which apparently guarded the road are to be ascribed to this period: el-Makhruq (no. 269), Mrah el-‘Enab (no. 191) and perhaps Umm ej-Juren (no. 200).

During Iron Age III, the Persian and Hellenistic Periods, there is a clear decrease in the number of sites, a phenomenon that characterizes the entire East Manasseh. The Byzantine Period (20 sites) has a peak of settlement, both in this landscape unit and in the entire region.

20. Ras Humsah

Although Ras Humsah comprises a topographic and geological contin-

uation to Jebel Tammun, its definition as a separate unit stems from its complexity and variety. The area of this unit is 35 sq. km and it is located between the Buqe'ah and Wadi Far'ah. In the south the unit takes on a triangular shape, and the border passes along the watershed of Ras el-Kharrubeh and descends southward to the delta of Wadi Far'ah.

The northwest part is a continuation of the panhandle of Jebel Tammun and contains the ranges of Ras Bil'am ez-Zef, Umm Rkab and Ras Humsah, which tower over their surroundings. Between them is the modern road from Wadi Far'ah to

Beqa'ot and Meholah (C23), but the ancient road passed through Wadi en-Naqb, as its name indicates (*naqb* = "pass" in Arabic).

Southeast of Ras Humsah is the Mutaqallabat, a small valley. To the east of the two valleys towers the bloc of Ras Kharrubeh, bordering Ras Humsah.

Most of the rocks of Ras Humsah are composed of Judah group and the soil is mountainous rendzina and brown forest soil. Most of the region is mountainous or hilly, but there are small, flat areas of cultivation in the Beqa'ot and Umm Rkab areas and in the valleys of Mutaqallabat and Mispah. There are no wa-



15. View of northern Buqe'ah from Ras Humsah. Moshav Beqa'ot is visible in mid-background and in distance is Ras Jadir. In rainy winters the Buqe'ah is the "granary" of East Manasseh.

ter sources in the region, but nearby Wadi Far'ah and the accumulation of rainwater in cisterns met the needs of the small sites. Aside from road C23, road C24 descends directly from Ras Humsah to Wadi Far'ah via the Kh. Mutaqallabat road.

Twenty eight sites were found on Ras Humsah (1.25 sq. km per site). Due to the characteristics of the area, most of them are small farms, courtyards or enclosures, seasonal structures or small fortresses. Not many multi period tells were found, and not even a single village. The average size of a site is 1 dunam (0.25 acre) or less, and in most cases a structure with a courtyard is the typical site. The reasons for this model are likely to be the proximity to Wadi Far'ah with its many multi period sites on the one hand, and the proximity to the Buqe'ah on the other. There are two principal periods: Iron Age II (17 sites or 61% of the total "presences")² and Byzantine Period (17 sites, also 61%). There are almost no sites of other periods, apart from Late Roman and Medieval, which have seven sites each. Thus Ras Humsah appears as a hinterland of the surrounding landscape units, which was settled mainly during the periods of increased population in the

neighboring areas. From an economic standpoint it again appears to be a marginal unit, whose population subsisted mainly on grain grown on small plots and flocks of sheep and goats.

The Iron Age deserves note due to the profusion of settlement and the special, round towers, similar to the Ammonite ones, which were found at four sites. Their concentration here and their absence in the other areas suggest a possible Ammonite influence. In particular, many Iron Age II-III sites are concentrated in Mutaqallabat Valley and these, too, may be ascribed to a particular group of settlers. Other multi period sites are the encampments, which were found in other areas as well. These are for the most part round enclosures (e.g., in Wadi 'Abd el-Al – site no. 211) or encampment areas in wadi beds, in which bases of tents or simple installations and ceramics of many periods were found.

21. The Desert Fringes

The name derives from the aridity of the area and its having clear distinctive marks of a desert fringe. The Mediterranean climate and its other characteristics disappear, to be replaced by prairie like features, particularly in the realm of precipitation and flora. While most of the landscape units extend from east to west in accordance with the geomorphologic structures, the

2 "Presences" include the number of the total periods in the sites. In a tell, for example, can be five to 15 "presences". Each "presence" symbolize one period within a given site.

desert fringe is a long strip from north to south, bordering on the Jordan Valley in the east and the local geological rift of Wadi Fau and the Buqe'ah in the west. The area of this unit is about 80 sq. km and its natural borders are easy to plot: in the west it borders the Meholah-Beqa'ot road and the ranges of Ras Humsah and Mutaqallabat Valley; in the east the Jordan Valley road (B10); in the north Wadi Malih and in the south the narrow tip of el-Makhruq.

The Desert Fringes is composed of marine limestone of the following geological variety of groups: Judah, Mount Scopus, Tiberias

and Avdat. It is characterized by long ranges which are generally oriented southwest-northeast. In their eastern part they descend in steep, rocky slopes toward the Jordan Valley. The high summits of the Desert Fringes are found in Umm Zoqah (257 m a.s.l.) and Ras el-Kharrubeh (216 m a.s.l.). The soil types include mountainous rendzina, brown basalt, desert and colluvial-alluvial. Due to its proximity to the Jordan Valley, the area is particularly hot in summer, and the flora is mostly annual *garigues* with a few bushes, mainly small (broombushes, etc.). Trees are few and include a variety of *Sisypus*, *Pistachia* etc. Water sources are lacking. The important



16. Some of the encampment sites are located in riverbeds protected from the winds. This enclosure in Wadi Abu Sidreh (center of photo, with figure inside) served for long periods of time.

roads which cross the area are the one from the Buqei'ah to the Jordan Valley in the south (C21), C23 in the west, and the Roman road ascending from Kh. es-Samrah (no. 129) to Kh. es-Suweideh (no. 239) and descending to the Jordan Valley (R2). The high bloc of Ras el-Kharrubeh in the southern part of the unit comprises an obstacle to passage.

There is a variety of site types in the Desert Fringes. The main model here, too, is the farm with courtyard, a family unit whose area is small (about 1.5 dunams or 0.4 acre) and whose settlers subsisted on cultivation of grain and raising flocks. Such sites comprise about 75% of the total in all the periods. Alongside these are villages about 5 to 10 dunams (1.25-2.5 acres) in size, like Tabqet el-Hilweh (no. 232), small towns like Kh. Mufyeh (no. 251), enclosures and encampments.

The Desert Fringes are divisible into two longitudinal strips, from the east and west to the local watershed of the unit. The western strip borders the relatively fertile areas, such as the Buqei'ah and Ras Jadir. The larger sites of the unit, mentioned above, are found in this strip. The eastern strip is particularly arid and almost completely unsettled. No site, except for army camps, is larger than one dunam (0.25 acre in size) and there are few permanent settlements. Aside from the

harsh conditions, there are the deep wadis that slice through the ridges and make passage difficult, and the steep slopes in the direction of the Jordan Valley. Of particular note, on this background, is the massive military presence from the Late Roman Period, including two camps (*castrae*) and two forts (*castellae*) along with everything they entail: roads, cemeteries and water installations. The last include dams and pools in adjacent channels from which the water was brought up to the military installations. This unusual system is linked to a special historical circumstances and the proximity to the Jordan Valley road, and not necessarily to the environmental conditions. Around the Roman camps there are no agricultural remains, thus excluding the possibility of civilian settlement.

A third group, smaller in scope, is the settlements near the Jordan Valley, primarily the groups of settlements north of Argaman and near Wadi Gharur. In these small settlements there is a considerable presence of Iron Age I-II periods, and although they are in the Desert Fringes it is preferable to attribute them to the Jordan Valley, and *cf.* volume four (LU 28, Zertal 2005, sites 36-74).

An interesting sub unit is found on Ras el-Kharrubeh in the south. Here, in an area of about 12 sq. km, are many encampments that lack any architecture. These are small,

relatively flat areas, such as a saddle or plateau, on which evidence of nomads' tents from numerous periods was found. In some cases a few remnants of the tent bases were discovered, made of small stones, and almost always a shard and flint tool scatter. They provide evidence that the same spot was returned to time after time and had suitable conditions for an encampment. About 80% of the encampment sites date to Iron Age II and Late Roman-Byzantine Periods.

In comparison to the other landscape units and because of the extreme conditions, settlement in the Desert Fringes was not a preferred choice of the population. The sites, totaling 47 in number (1.7 sq. km per site) comprise a unique group, affected by the aridity of the region and proximity to the Jordan Valley. There are three Chalcolithic Period sites, the exception of which is the village at 'Ain Hilu (B - no. 230), with no Early Bronze Age sites. The most prominent periods are Iron Age II (14 sites) and Byzantine Period (25 sites). Also found were Middle Bronze Age I (four sites) and Middle Bronze Age II (seven sites). The few Iron Age I settlements are concentrated mainly in the area of Argaman, Ras el-Kharrubeh and Kh. es-Suweideh. Iron Age II sites were mostly small family farms (e.g., the farm at Abu Sha'areh, no. 246). During the Persian and Hellenistic Periods there was almost no

settlement, while in the Late Roman (ten sites), Early Moslem (four sites) and Medieval (11 sites) periods, settlement was concentrated mainly in the western strip. The increase during the Byzantine period (25 sites) indicates the ability to adapt and exploit the land.

D. Notes on the Pottery of East Manasseh

This chapter presents several ceramic "families", both those particular to the region and those that present a chronological or other problem. The ceramic discussion in the previous volume (Zertal 2004, 40-45) included most of the periods, while here we focus on the periods or ceramic "families" unique to the region or comprising a problem or innovation.

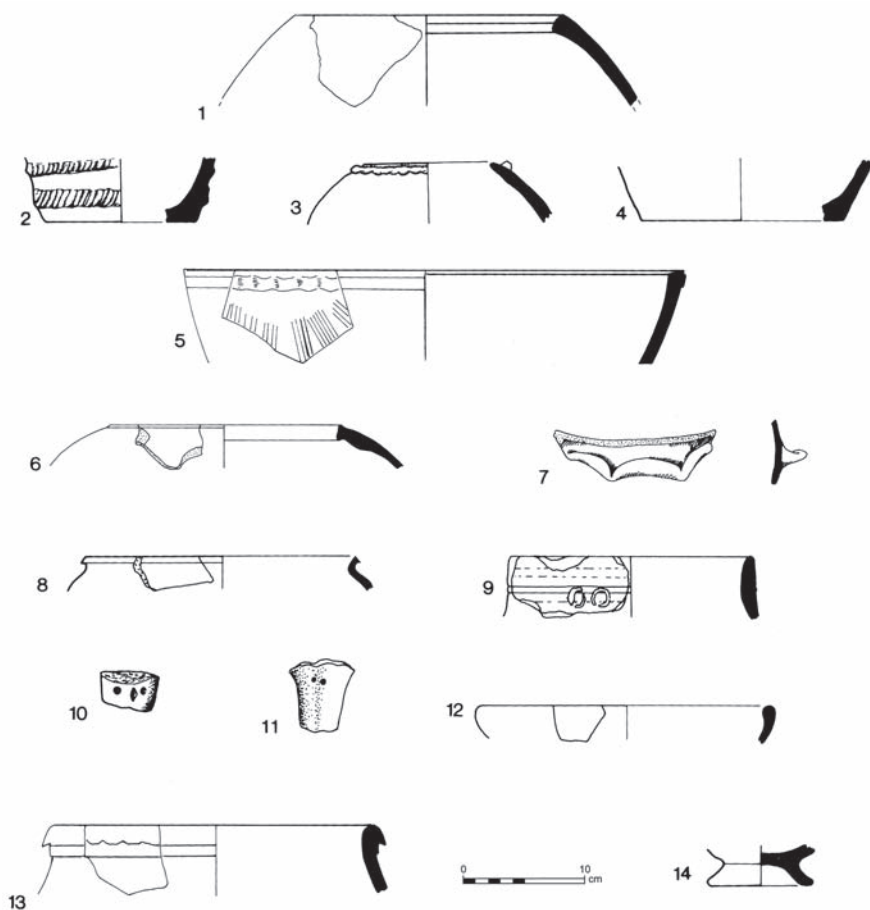
1. *Chalcolithic-Early Bronze Age I ("Far'ah family" - fig. 17;1-4)*

In the upper part of Wadi Far'ah, a special regional ceramic family is discerned whose date is difficult to determine and controversial. The vessels are light brown in color, are well fired and are outstanding in the profusion of rope decorations on the body and along the rim, loop handles, high ear handles, and protruding small decorations. Most of the vessels are hole mouth jars, sometimes with slit rims, together with bowls and especially very large basins with thickened rims. There

are also plain ledge handles, some of which bear a cogwheel design along the narrow side of the handle.

These vessels, already published by De Vaux (1947, fig. 2; 1948, fig. 5) in his excavations at Tel el-

Far'ah are termed by him as "Upper Neolithic" (*eneolithique superieure*). Parallels are found in Glueck's survey of Transjordan (Umm Hamad esh-Sharqi), Beth Shean XIV, Jericho VII (Pottery Neolithic B)



17. Several ceramic types which characterize East Menasseh: 1. Hole mouth jar, red slip, "Far'ah Family"; 2. Basin, rope decoration, "Far'ah Family"; 3. Hole mouth jar, rope decoration on rim, "Far'ah Family"; 4. "V shaped" bowl, gray, "Far'ah Family"; 5. Large bowl, brown-gray, thin rope decoration with impression, MBA I; 6-7. Hole mouth jar with split rim and curled ledge handle, yel, MBA I; 8. Type A cooking pot, dk brn, IrA IA; 9. Collared rim pythos with reed impression, brn, IrA I; 10-11. Handles decorated with indentations and "man faces", brn, IrA IA-B; 12. "Manassite" bowl, brn, IrA IA; 13. Jug with stepped rim, lt brn, "Eynun Family", IrA IA; 14. Large trumpet base of bowl, lt brn, "Eynun Family", IrA IA.

and others. De Vaux notes (1947, 402) that some of these ceramic phenomena are similar to those of Early Bronze Age I, and that there is ceramic continuity between the two periods. This is expressed in the profusion of rope decoration, a common phenomenon in later periods as well (*ibid* 1948, fig. 6) and in the perforated handles, not characteristic in Early Bronze Age in other regions.

De Vaux does not mention Chalcolithic Period ceramics in his discussion, although it appears in his excavations. The Ghassulian Chalcolithic Period pottery includes loop handles as an important element, while many rope decorations on the body are rare, except on the giant pythoi. In the figures of the "Neolithic" vessels he presents, such as that of tomb 3 (*ibid* 1949, fig. 1) and tomb 5 (*ibid*, fig. 8) are vessels that clearly belong to Early Bronze Age I. Such are, e.g., the jugs with high "basket" handles, juglets with two loop handles where the neck is connected to the body, etc. From this it seems that the definition as "Upper Neolithic" is problematic. In the last years additional excavations in Transjordan (Helms 1992) has shown stratigraphically that "Chalcolithic-Early Bronze Age I" is practically Early Bronze Age I. The flint tool finds provide more evidence of this stage (and see Appendix on flint, the discussion of Jellamet el-Ahmar). Due to the lim-

ited area in which it appears, Wadi Far'ah and its environs, it was called "Far'ah Family", a term now much extended and joined into the Early Bronze Age I world.

2. *Middle Bronze Age I ("Early Bronze Age IV")*

Three phenomena are unique of this period in the region (fig. 17:5-7):

- a. Instead of the incised "pattern decoration" design on the neck, there is usually a thin, molded strip. It is 3-4 mm wide and is pasted on the neck before firing, with a delicate design of rope decoration. In some cases the decoration, a distinctive mark of the joining of the neck and body, is barely visible.

- b. On the body of the vessel is a particularly special, impressed decoration. This impression is produced by pressing the wide part of a comb's teeth into the clay while it is still soft. The resultant design is somewhat similar to "pattern combing" of Early Bronze Age II (Amiran 1969, pl. 17:15), but it is formed by pressing and not by combing. Possible correlations in Transjordan occur in Palumbo (1991, figs. 55:1-3; 56:1-3). This type of decoration, very common in the area, possibly provides a link between Early Bronze Age and Middle Bronze Age.

- c. Especially noticeable is the dark gray to almost black clay of

the “Umm Hamad el-Gharbi” type, which was first discovered in Transjordan by Glueck (1951, tables 17, 93). Gophna and Porath (1972, 197) noted that these were typical of the Wadi Far‘ah area, and our survey broadened their distribution. The proposal of Gophna and Porath (*ibid, ibid*) according to which these characterize “a certain wave of settlers from Middle Canaanite Period I” remains open.

The vessels from this period are noteworthy for their great homogeneity: among the prominent ones are jars with flaring rims, hole mouth jars with cut inner rim, large bowls with ledge rim and impressed decoration, and others. Distinctive marks in the survey were the folded, double and quadruple ledge handles, squashed loop handles of the jugs, and more. The local family is light while the dark one possibly originates in Transjordan.

3. Middle Bronze Age II

The absence of Middle Bronze Age IIA pottery is worthy of mention. Vessels with polished red slip that characterize this period were not found (although it should be noted that slip appears mostly on small vessels, which are difficult to find in a survey).

The pottery vessels of the second stage (Middle Bronze Age IIA-B) are mostly similar to those of the Mediterranean region (Zertal 2004,

42) with certain differences:

a. The profusion of bowls with rims folded inward, which also appeared in the Mediterranean region, is noteworthy. This type dominates in the eastern area, where other types of bowls are absent (in the survey), such as the carinated or open and rounded ones. This situation is similar in Shechem and Tel el-Far‘ah (Cole 1984, type BP51-52, table 4). It is possible that this bowl was particularly characteristic of East Manasseh (although it frequently appears in Ephraim and Benjamin as well, such as in Feldstein *et al.* 1992, 150:2-3, etc.). In any case, it seems that this bowl was especially popular in the area to the east of the national watershed. The type appears late in the period (toward Middle Bronze Age IIC – 1650-1550 BCE).

b. In jars in East Manasseh, rope decorations on the shoulders, which frequently appear in the Mediterranean region, are absent. A few rope and fishbone decorations are found on bowl rims here; it is difficult to determine the significance of this phenomenon.

c. The distribution of the types of cooking pots is very similar to the Mediterranean zone and here, too, about 80% of the inventory of cooking pots have folded rims. This reinforces the picture of “late” settlement in the period, since the perforated, hand-made cooking pot (absent in this area) is slightly ear-

lier.

4. *Iron Age I* (*"Israelite settlement"*)

In the 250 years of the period, the pottery of the region bears special significance, although there is some similarity to the Mediterranean region. The difference between the areas is mainly in quantity, but pottery here is closely related to the settlement process:

a. Plastic decoration and indentations: some of the East Manasseh ceramics show relatively many indentation decorations on the handles and rims, before firing, in various models. These have been discussed widely in various works (e.g., Zertal 1986-87, 140-147, and especially fig. 20; 1988, 289-294; Finkelstein 1986, 260-262 and lately Cohen 2005). Here we repeat only the characteristics relevant to this volume:

1. The decoration appears neither in Late Bronze Age nor in Iron Age II;

2. It is restricted mainly to the Manasseh Hill Country and northern Mount Ephraim;

3. Its presence is concentrated mainly in the Shechem Syncline.

According to the survey finds, the indented decoration characterizes mostly the "heart" of Manasseh, and its relative quantities, as collected from the surface of sites, grow smaller the farther west and

east the site is.

In the excavations at Mount Ebal, indented decorations were discovered in two levels (II and IB), roughly representing the 13th and 12th centuries BCE, and it seems that the amount of vessels that were decorated grows smaller towards the 11th century BCE, although not disappearing completely. Thus, we have proposed that the indented decoration can be utilized, with certain reservation, as an additional guide for the relative chronology of Iron Age I sites. In Tel el-Far'ah and in Taanach the above appears in the 11th century BCE, but this matter requires clarification (see also the discussion of Zertal 1988, 276-279, 282-284).

b. Distribution of cooking pots: Following A. Mazar (1981, 20-23) a division of types of cooking pots was suggested into type A (short rim, in Late Bronze Age tradition, mainly 13th century BCE), B (12th and early 11th century BCE) and C (11th and 10th centuries BCE)³. In counting cooking pot rims on the surface of the sites it turns out that the relative distribution of the earlier type A is far greater in the Jordan Valley and along the wadis Far'ah and Malih. Type B "replaces" it more and more the farther west the sites are; thus the gradual foundation of sites from east to west is a

3 To these type D should be added, dating to the Iron Age II (10th to 7th centuries BCE).

possible explanation.

c. The “Manassite” bowl, with thickened rims folded inward, is relatively common in the eastern areas.

The relative ceramic “purity” of the Iron Age I sites in the east, *i.e.*, the absence of Late Bronze Age sites, is a further phenomenon, which ease the above analysis. These preliminary conclusions are based on a surface survey; their significance should not be overestimated and must be proven or refuted in stratigraphic excavations.

d. “Eynun Family”: These are vessels with characteristics of Middle Bronze Age II and Late Bronze Age, that were first found in an Iron Age I site (Kh. ‘Eynun, no. 58), and later in other sites in the area (cf. also Mazar 1999; Zertal 2003). The features of the above are:

1. High, trumpet bases for the jugs and some of the jars;
2. “Stepped” rims for the jars, in the style of Middle Bronze Age II.

These two phenomena are absent from the regular pottery of Iron Age I, but the ware is identical to that period, differing from that of the Middle Bronze Age. Also absent are other Middle Bronze Age vessels: bowls, jars, cooking pots, etc. In conclusion, The ware and vessels from Kh. ‘Eynun are only Iron Age I, with certain morphological characteristics of Middle Bronze Age II.

5. Iron Age III (Assyrian conquest)

The bowl with wedge decoration has been discussed in several places (Zertal 1989b; 2004, 44). The Cuthaeen settlement of the 8th-7th centuries BCE was quite intensive in the eastern valleys, and there are settlements in which most of the pottery is from this period. In 20 sites and more this special bowl was found; it is also represented, with less frequency, in Wadi Far‘ah and the desert fringe areas. The usual inventory is comprised of hole mouth jars with a wide ledge rim, ridged jars with sharp rims and “late” cooking pots. Once a connection is proven between the Cuthaeen settlement and the above pottery, we will be able to draw an approximate map in which the exiles from Mesopotamia settled.

6. The Late Periods (from Early Moslem Period to the End of Ottoman Period)

These periods have been the most “neglected” from the ceramic point of view, and it seems to us that their internal division is insufficient. In particular, it is worthwhile to note the lack of research within the Early Moslem Period (Umayyad, Fatimid and Abasside, etc.) as well as the necessity for a better division of the Mameluk Period until the Ottoman conquest and within the long Ottoman Period itself.

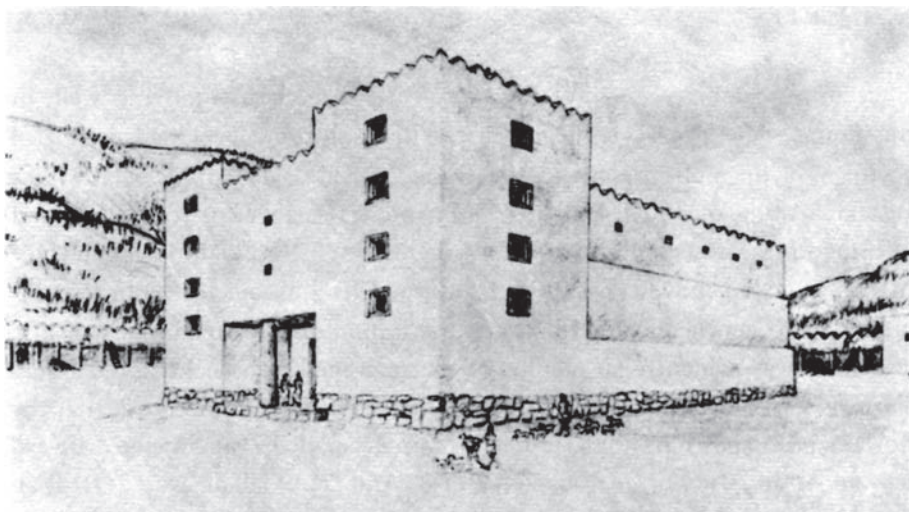
E. Outlines of the History of East Manasseh

This review intends to sketch the role of the region in the general historical framework, in the Manasseh Hill Country as a whole and in relation to a description of the settlement. We have avoided attempting to encompass all of the historical events and to go into detail, and our purpose was, and remains, giving general outlines instead.

East Manasseh does not stand alone, but comprises an echo and a reflection of what is occurring around it. Such behavior, which can be termed a “settlement shadow” to the main events, typifies remote and arid regions. Only in a few periods is the settlement here clearly unique; this is the situation, e.g., during Middle Bronze Age I and

Iron Age I. The area was influenced by three administrative and settlement centers surrounding it: the Mediterranean zone of Manasseh, the city of Beth Shean with its valley and Transjordan.

The historical information concerning the ancient periods is limited. Shechem and its environs are mentioned in the tomb of Khu-Sebek (from the days of Pharaoh Sesotris III, ca. 1880-1840 BCE, during the 12th Dynasty in Egypt), in the form of “the land of Skmm... which fell together with wretched r-t-n-u” (ANET 230). The name “the foreign land named Shechem” may indicate the importance of the city in the 19th century BCE. In the Execration Texts, Beth Shean and Shechem are mentioned (the former is E3, in Sethe group, and the latter is E6). This again indicates the



18. Reconstruction of the tower temple from MBA and LBA in Shechem (Tel Ballatah, as reconstructed by the Drew/McCormick Expedition – from Wright 1965, 46).

significance of the cities and their regions (for a partial literature cf. Mazar 1947; Posener 1940; Goetze 1958; Mazar 1986d, 9 ff; Weinstein 1975; Redford 1992; Hutton 1992). The mention of Shechem generally fits the excavation results, but the archaeological finds do not confirm settlement prosperity in the first quarter of the second millennium BCE (Middle Bronze Age IIA, the period of the Middle Kingdom in Egypt). Northern Transjordan, together with the regions of Bashan and the Jordan Valley, located opposite to East Manasseh, are also mentioned extensively in the Execration Texts.

In the el-Amarnah letters, Shechem (al-Ili), the main city of Labayu, is mentioned in detail, but with no specific relationship to East Manasseh. In the stela of Seti I from Beth Shean, from the end of the 14th or the beginning of the 13th century BCE, an Egyptian military campaign to subjugate the "Apiru of Mount Yarimtu" is mentioned (Gradzeloff 1949; ANET 255). The Apiru attacked, together with certain "Tir", another tribe called "Rem". The location of Mount Yarimtu is unknown. On the basis of the name "Yarmuth" in Joshua 21:29, which was a satellite city in Issachar, Albright (1952, 24 ff.) proposed identifying Mount Yarimtu as the highlands of Issachar. But the settlement in this area (north of Beth Shean) was very sparse in the

13th century BCE, and Gal (1980, 84) casting doubt on Albright's identification. On the basis of the same document, it can be posited that this Mount Yarimtu is located to the south and not to the north of Beth Shean. The Jordan Valley and East Manasseh are relatively rich in settlements from the 13th century BCE. This proposal is preferable to Albright's; in Seti's stela there is no indication as of the location of the Apiru tribes.

The detailed Biblical references to the area are noteworthy. The Valley of Succoth east of the Jordan played a crucial role in the crystallization of the Israelite tribes (Mazar 1986b), and was a link between Transjordan and Canaan, whose historical boundary passed along the Jordan River (De Vaux 1968). Goitein (1965) and Mazar (1986b, 170) emphasizes the traditions in Psalms (78:59-60) regarding the cultic centers near the Succoth Valley. The comparison between Shiloh and Adam (the city, *ibid.*, 170) and the traditions in Joshua (6:7-8; 22) and in Psalms (83:11; 78, 60-61) regarding the ritual and tactical importance of the region, comprise part of the above traditions (see also the "sociological" discussion of Gottwald 1979, 573-577). In Joshua and Judges, East Manasseh is frequently mentioned as a focus of the tribal struggles and the wars between the Canaanites and the Israelites. The traditions of *Bezeq* in

Judges 1:1-10 and I Samuel 11:8, concerning the war between the Canaanites and the Israelites, and the journey of Saul to *Yabesh Gilead*, have been widely discussed by scholars, yet the location of *Bezeq* have not been positively identified (see especially Welten 1965). The proposals of identifying *Bezeq* as Kh. Ibziq (no. 44) or Kh. Salhab (no. 23, and see chapter three on identifications) may shed light upon the historical authenticity of the story. While the reality of Adonibezek the King of *Bezeq* and his city is difficult to determine, Saul's campaign illuminates the very existence of *Bezeq*. In addition, the appearance of the tribes of Judah and Simeon in the heart of the Manassite allot-

ment poses another problem. It can be interpreted and understood, on the background of the concentration of various Israelite proto tribes and families in Manasseh in the 13th-12th centuries (*cf.* discussion in Zertal 2000, 400-446), as a primary stage in the settlement process. De Pury (1969), Lemaire (1978) and others have also suggested early settlement in the region of Wadi Far'ah, even before the discoveries of the Manasseh Survey were published.

Other important events relating to the crystallization of early Israel, along with the intertribal relationships during the 12th-11th centuries BCE, occurred in East Manasseh (Lemaire 1972; 1982;



19. A typical encampment of nomads in Wadi Far'ah. Similar sites are known in the IrA I and other periods.

1984). This must have happened around Shechem, in the mountains of Garizim and Ebal, the eastern valleys (Tubas, Zebabdeh, and the *Michmetath*) and the sites of *Bezeq*, *Thebez*, *Arumah* and the Jordan Valley. The Mediterranean parts and West Manasseh are barely mentioned in this context, a fact which supports the notion that early Israel emerged in the east. This presumption is highly significant; our research shows that Shechem and Mount Ebal (Zertal 1993c) served as the earliest cult places of the Israelite families, where religion and nationalism were crystallized⁴. The movements of Abimelech occurred around Shechem, *Arumah* and *Thebez* (cf. also Malamat 1983, 104-110). *Thebez* was identified by Eusebius, bishop of Caesarea in the 4th century CE, as the village of Tubas (Eusebius Onomasticon – Freeman-Graneville, Chapman and Taylor 2003, no. 100, p. 160). This is a large village so named in the 13th mile from *Neapolis*, which may also suit “Thopas” of the Middle Ages. *Thebez* is identified by us either as Kh. ‘Eynun (no. 58) or as Kh. Fuqahah (no. 47) – both in the Tubas Valley. The two sites, founded in the early Iron Age, have impressive fortifications (on the Tubas Valley as a link between the two

entrances of the Israelite tribes, see discussion on the landscape units, section no. 14 above). During the survey, the earliest pottery of the Iron Age was detected in the Jordan Valley and the valleys of Far‘ah (*Tirzah*) and Malih. Later on, the focus moves westwards and southwards (Zertal 1991).

The high place on Mt. Ebal (13th-12th centuries BCE) highlights this notion. The site is located in East Manasseh and relates also to the ancient cultic traditions of Canaanite Shechem (Mazar 1992b). It is not accidental, therefore, that the site was founded in east Ebal, overlooking Wadi Far‘ah and East Manasseh. On Mt. Ebal important cultic traditions were concentrated, expressed in Deuteronomy and Joshua (Zertal 1985; 1986-1987; Kempinski 1986 *vs.* Zertal 1986b; Finkelstein 1988, 77-80; Dever 1992 *vs.* Zertal 1992b, etc.).

The town of *Tirzah* (Tel el-Far‘ah) was also a significant center in the area (Mazar 1992a). It appears in the list of the conquered Canaanite cities in Joshua 12:24, yet the excavations by the French expedition failed to detect a destruction level from that period. The town in the end of the Bronze Age was small and unfortified.

De Vaux (1992, 1300), who directed the dig (and see also Chambon 1993, 439)⁵, dates the end of

⁴ This opinion, already written back in 1995, has slightly changed now [2006], as the importance of the Jordan Valley has begun to emerge, and see Zertal 2005, 64-69.

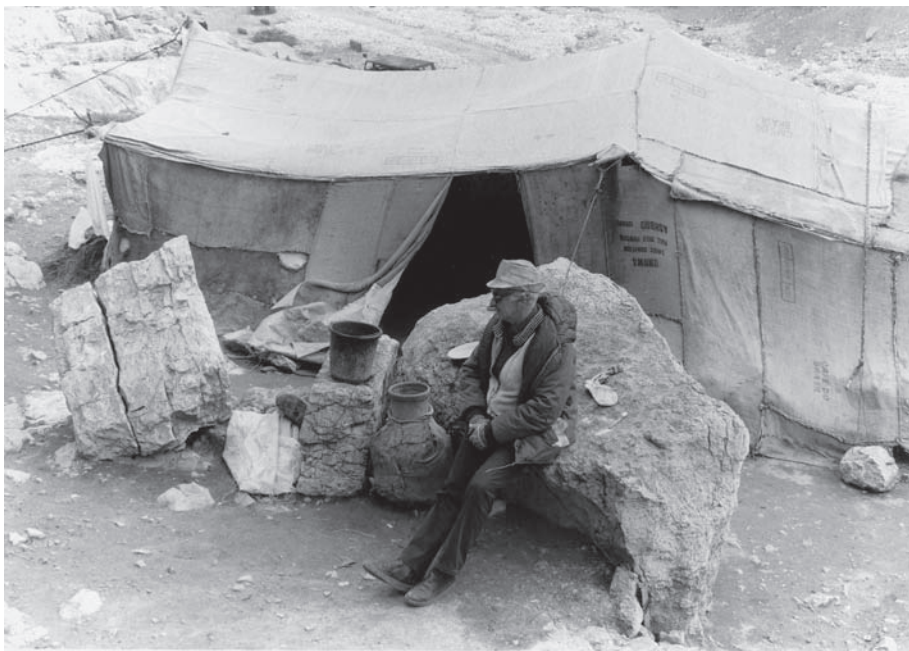
⁵ In the Hebrew edition of the *New Encyclopaedia of Excavations* it was De Vaux

the Canaanite town in the 14th century, with the meager possibility that it existed “also” into the 13th. According to the report, the earliest Iron Age pottery can be dated not before the 11th century (*cf.* analysis in Zertal 1988, 282-284), and during the 12th century the place was deserted. If so, the Israelites “conquered” the city at a later date and its mention in Joshua 12 is etiological. Later on, *Tirzah* (the Biblical name of Tel Far’ah) was the third capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, following Shechem and *Penuel* and preceding Samaria (I Kings 14:17). The fact that all the early capitals of Israel were located in East Manasseh, and east of the

national watershed, should be noted, together with the significance of the Wadi Far’ah road. This road is named in the Book of Deuteronomy (11:30) as “the road where the sun goes down”, having been a central link between the Israelite tribes in Transjordan and those in Cisjordan on one hand, and between the kingdom in the west and the Israelite regions in the east on the other.

During the United Monarchy of David and Solomon (10th century BCE) Shechem continued to play a central role as a religious center, but not as a fortified city (*cf.* Mazar 1992b; Campbell 1993, 1352-1353). In that city the Monarchy disintegrated and, again, the strong ties with Transjordan and the Jor-

(1992, 1297-1320) who wrote the entry.



20. A typical nomads' tent in East Mannaseh with the “Zir”, a large pythos for water.

dan Valley are well expressed. During the United Monarchy the Jordan Valley saw intensive activity related to copper processing, an activity not yet discovered archaeologically. These strong ties between east and west are testified to by the fort system on the three roads ascending from east to west: Wadi Malih, Wadi Far'ah and that of the Mejdal Bani Fadil (Yeivin 1992; Zertal 1995). These forts, of the "Malfuf" type, are all identical in plan, measurements and, presumably, date of foundation.

An additional aspect of the Iron Age is the district system of King Solomon (I Kings 4:7-10). It seems that a part of East Manasseh belonged to the 5th District, together with the valleys of Jezreel and Beth Shean (*idem*, 12). "All Beth Shean" may include the terms "to Abel Meholah until beyond Yoqmeam" (and *cf.* the parallel – "all the land of Hephher" – I Kings 4:10). *Abel Meholah* seems well to be identified now at Tel Abu Sus on the Jordan River (and *cf.* Zobel 1966; Zori 1977, site 56; Zertal 2005, site 33), and *Yoqmeam* – in Kh. Qa'un or the like (Zertal 2005, site 3 and p. 96). It is, however, hard to determine the exact borders of the 5th District. Mazar's (1992c, 139) opinion, according to which the border "stretched" southwards to Wadi Far'ah, now seems difficult to accept. Alt (1953), loyal to his historical scheme about the Solo-

monic districts, has suggested that the 5th District was an ex-Canaanite region.

To continue this notion, we may suppose that East Manasseh and the Jordan Valley were, during the LBA, part of the Canaanite territories of Beth Shean, *Rehob* and probably *Hamath* (Tel el-Hama, and *cf.* Zertal 2005, site 30).

At the end of the United Monarchy, around 925 BCE, Shishaq's campaign to Palestine had great influence on the area (Mazar 1986a). Following his conquest of the hill country, the pharaoh descended to the city of *a-d-m-h* (*Adam Ha'ir* – Damiyeh) in the Jordan Valley (Mazar 1986a, 145-148). If indeed the *m-g-d-l* of Shishaq (n. 58 in the list) is to be identified as Rujum Abu Muheir (Bar Adon 1972, site 10), then the fort can be dated to the end of the 10th century, yet such "historical" dating is very uncertain.

During the later Israelite kingdom (10th-8th centuries BCE) the political focus moved westwards (Zertal 2001). The foundation of Samaria and the government of the House of Omri are indications of the growing influence of the Mediterranean regions of Manasseh. This process appears together with the pacts with the Phoenician mercantile city of Tyre, undoubtedly on the account of the Transjordanian tribes. However, East Manasseh continues to play a role: King Je-

roboam had a house in *Tirzah* (I Kings 14:17) and the above mentioned roads were much in use during the Aramaean invasions west of the Jordan (I Kings 20:1-23). Yadin (1955) has suggested that the Valley of *Succoth* (facing Wadi Far'ah, cf. Mazar 1986b) was used as a military basis by both King David and Ben Hadad the Aramaean; this is supported by our finds.

The period of Iron Age II (the Kingdom of Israel) is signified by intensive settlement in East Manasseh, above all by villages and farms, while the Mediterranean regions enjoy the same prosperity. This prosperity, not directly mentioned in the books of Kings, was registered during the survey in the

landscape units of Wadi Far'ah (LU 19), Ras Humsah (LU 20) and the Fringes of the Desert (LU 21). In four of the sites, round towers were detected, similar to the "Malfuf" type of Transjordan. Their diameter is 16-20 m and they are composed, in most cases, of three concentric circles. Glueck identified them as Ammonite in type (Mackenzie 1911; Glueck 1937). It can be suggested that they signify possible Ammonite penetration into these regions, as echoed by Amos (1:13).

The decline in settlement during Iron Age III (7th-6th centuries BCE) is probably the product of the Assyrian occupation, followed by large, forced movements of populations. During this period



21. The delta of Wadi Far'ah seen from Ras Kharrubeh.

the development of the Cuthaeen-Samaritan community is recorded. It emerged from the Israeli populace of the kingdom together with exiles brought from outside. They were composed of groups from Elam, the Habur region, southern Mesopotamia and Arabic elements, brought by the Assyrian kings: Sargon II and those who followed. The wedge-shaped bowls can now be offered as evidence of those sites where the exiles brought from Mesopotamia were settled by the Assyrians (for the bowls, *cf.* Zertal 1989b). Most of those settlements are located in East Manasseh – especially in the valleys of Zebabdeh and Tubas. This can be explained by the existence of kings' lands in these areas. Some bowls, however, are known in landscape units further to the east (Ras Jadir, Wadi Malih and the Desert Fringes).

During the Persian and Hellenistic periods the area does not play an important role. The information is meager, and the focus moves westwards, to the Mediterranean regions. This can be seen by the development of the capital city of Samaria, the sites surrounding it and the general importance of the *pahwah* of Samaria (Zertal 1989a; Lemaire 1994, 41-46). At the end of the Persian period East Manasseh seems to have become a "shelter region", where fugitives could find asylum. The caves of Wadi Daliyeh, containing finds of

Samaritan fugitives, are an example of that process (Cross 1992; Lapp 1993). In this period the territory plays the same role as the Judaeen Desert for Jerusalem.

The Jordan Valley and the desert fortresses are quite significant during the Hasmonaeen (Late Hellenistic) period, but no direct information relating to East Manasseh exists. Bar Kochba (1980, 365-369) assumes that the Seleucid general Bacchides passed through the Jordan Valley during his second campaign to the battle of *El'asah* (Nisan 180 BCE).

This road continued to play a role in the Early Roman Period (Herodian) period, but no events are known in our area of volume two. Upon meager data, Safrai (1986, 141-147) made a division between "the desert of *Aqrabim*" and "the desert of Tammun", both within the same zone; but no new historical information is provided. Unlike the Jewish region of *Aqrabata* to the south, the territory discussed here was settled by Samaritans and gentiles. John Hyrcanus annexed *Aqrabata* to Judaea, followed by Gabinus after the conquest of Judaea by Pompey (63-62 BCE).

When the first Jewish revolt against the Romans began in 66 CE, Yohanan Ben Hananiyah was nominated as commander of the regions of *Gophna* and *Aqrabata* (Wars II, 568), where Jews dwelt from the time of the Second Tem-

ple (Avi Yonah 1966, 122). The fact that Josephus (*Wars* I, 134) defines *Coraea* (Tel Simmadi, and cf. Zertal 2005, site 80) as “the beginning of Judaea” indicates that the area north of Wadi Far’ah was not included in the region of *Agrabata*. During the revolt, Vespasian descended to the Jordan Valley through Wadi Far’ah: “and from there he (Vespasian) went to *Qarawah* and slept there... and in the morrow directed toward Jericho.” (*Wars* IV, 450). This is an additional indication that Wadi Far’ah and its road were known as the border between two entities: East Samaria to the north, inhabited by Samaritans and gentiles, and Jewish Judaea to the south.

The newly discovered Roman military system in the Fringes of the Desert poses new problems. The system was composed of two large Roman camps, in Tel Shalem and Kh. Suweideh (no. 239, cf. Hashman 1996), a smaller camp (Kh. Gharur, no. 259) and two forts: Kh. Khiraf (no. 266) and ‘Iraq Abu Hashish (no. 248). This system has no other example in the Holy land and the circumstances of its foundation and chronology are as yet unknown. In addition, the camps seem to have existed for a short time-span: 100-150 years.

It is tempting to relate the system to the later stages of the Bar Kochba war (the second revolt against the Romans – 132-135 CE). The historical sources do not provide us

with information as to the Roman march toward the centers of Bar Kochba in Judaea and its desert, so it can be only assumed that the Roman high command chose to move along the Jordan Valley. The population here and in the Transjordanian Decapolis was most probably anti Jewish or, at least, indifferent. The Jordan Valley and the Desert Fringes offered good roads and neighboring gentile cities: Scythopolis and Neapolis. The Roman road at Kh. es-Suweideh, which descends to the Jordan Valley road B10, was dated to Hadrian’s time through an inscribed milestone found close to B10 road (Isaac 1978, 49).

The Byzantine period presents several new historical sources. The list of the “permitted towns” in the territory of Sebasteh, found in the synagogue of *Rehob*, include gentile sites within the Samaritan entity (Demskey 1979; Safrai 1980, 138-141; Zussman 1981). Six out of the 17 sites mentioned in the list are located within our area: ‘Iqbin (‘Aqaba – no. 22); Sir (no. 20); Azilin (el-Khirbeh [Zard]? – no. 14); Shapirin (Safiriyan – no. 2); ‘Ananin (Kh. Anahum? – no. 1) and Palga d’Shalaf (Salhab? – no. 23). The territory thus created is enclosed in the north by the eastern valleys, Zebabdeh and Sir. This poses the question of other regions in East Manasseh. Demsky’s opinion, according to which the sites are arranged along road lines, is hard

to accept, for not less important roads pass east of this region without such sites. Is it possible that the Samaritan populace was limited by the Christian population that dwelt to their east. Evidence of this is the monastery at Kh. Jabaris (no. 69) with its Byzantine Period church inscription, together with possible church remains in Kh. Yarzah (B – no. 104).

On the other hand, the inscriptions from Kh. Ibziq (lower - no. 42) indicate the presence of Samaritans (or Jews?) along the Scythopolis - Neapolis road (B7). Here, the milestones show the distance to Neapolis, a fact suggesting that the region belonged to this important city. It was Eusebius as well who noted the distances from the same city (but *cf.* Pekkari 1968, 138-148, and Isaac 1978, 57-59. They both argues against territories' boundaries indicated by milestones). Safrai (1980, 145-147) suggested that this area belonged to either Sebasteh or functioned as an independent toparchy; yet neither theory seems to have factual evidence.

To the sites along the B7 road *Bethmeulah*, south of Beth Shean (now Kh. Sakkut, Zertal 2005, no. 32) is added. In any case, the border between the territories of the two cities passed somewhere in East Manasseh. Fuchs (1983, 110-113 and map in P. 112) has put forward the idea that the territory of Scythopolis penetrated into the

Neapolis region in the form of "enclaves" along the main roads.

The territory undoubtedly suffered during the Samaritan uprisings against the Byzantine Period government under the emperors Zenon and Justinian (in the years 484, 529 and 555 CE). When the Samaritan leader Baba Raba divided the country into districts, only Haifa and the Galilee were represented north of Samaria. This stands in contrast to the detailed administrative division of Samaria and the coast (Avi Yonah 1956, 129). During the uprising of 529 CE Malalas speaks of the burning of Christian houses at Scythopolis and the government of Julianus, one of the revolt leaders. The Samaritan community in Scythopolis is known from various texts (Di Segni 1988, 223). From there the uprising continued to Neapolis where churches were burned, Christians were killed and a quasi-government of the Samaritans was founded. Another version speaks of the beginning of the uprising in Neapolis (Avi Yonah 1956; Di Segni 1988, 226; Fishman Ducker 1988, 174-176). It can be concluded that the clashes between Samaritans and Christians took place in East Manasseh, within the toparchies (regions) of Neapolis and Scythopolis. Malalas speaks of the Samaritans' flight, after their defeat, to Transjordan, to Trachonis and "the iron mountain" near Wadi Zerqa. Taking that route, they must

have passed through the region discussed here, where they could probably find allies. Avi Yonah (1956, 130) argues that the Samaritans did not attack Scythopolis due to the inability of the former to conduct warfare on two fronts. The Samaritan leader of the 529 CE uprising, Julianus the son of Sabar, informs Malalas, retreated from Neapolis to the east "to better fight". It can be concluded, therefore, that the population in East Manasseh was a mixture of Christians (majority) and Samaritans (minority). The latter, consequently, was much weakened following the events.

Information about the region during the Early Moslem Period dynasties (Umayyad, Abassides and Fatimids) and the Crusaders is partial. East Manasseh belonged administratively, during the Moslem government, to Jind el-Urdun with its capital in Tiberias (Gil 1981, map on p. 77). The territory of Nablus – Shechem was transferred later to Jind Filastin with Ramleh as capital. The thorough work of Beyer (1940) about the settlement around Nablus during the Crusader Period mentions only few sites in our area, mostly located in the eastern valleys (Tubas) and the Jordan Valley. One of these, *Bethphorum* (Kh. Bet Farr (B), no. 168) is situated in Wadi Far'ah.

The area is empty as well in the map of the Crusader castles (Shein 1981, map on p. 314). The two

medieval castles, Burj el-Far'ah (no. 150) and Burj el-Malih (no. 89) are either not mentioned in the sources or are unidentified. This raises the problem of the communication with Crusader Transjordan. The connection to the Crusader castles in the Gilead must have been through the roads of East Manasseh. Burj el-Malih stands at a strategic point overlooking the road along the wadi, but such a castle is absent at the entrance to Wadi Far'ah. The late Middle Ages are not defined by a settlement decline, and the entire issue warrants further research.

During the Mameluk Period the region was divided into *villayas* (districts) belonging to the territory of Damascus, and a network of roads was developed with road stations. At the end of the 13th century CE the Mameluk sultan Baibars built the Damiyeh bridge over the Jordan to ease the communication from es-Salt to Nablus (Drori 1981, 34). It can be assumed that one, at least, of those stations was located along Wadi Far'ah. An additional Mameluk road passed along the road B7, from Beisan to Nablus.

The 14th century is illuminated through the travel diary of Ashtori Ha Parhi, an Italian-Jewish traveler. He stayed in Beisan and went along the road to Nablus, passing by Ibziq and Tubas (*Kaphtor va-Perah* 1897, 287). Other information speaks of a Bedouin attack on the mail road east of Beisan in 1349 CE. This

road was a part of the Damascus – Cairo main road, and its section should have passed through the Jordan Valley. The products taken by the Bedouins (sugar and honey) are evidence of the local agriculture. The Moslem geographer Muqadasi speaks, already in the 10th century CE, of the sugar cane industry in the Jordan Valley. A different source speaks of a battle in Wadi Far'ah between the Mameluk sultan Barquq, who set out from Kerak to Cairo with Transjordanian Bedouins, and the governor of Gaza, who left Nablus heading 5000 Bedouins and advanced toward Barquq.

The second half of the Mameluk period (14th-15th centuries CE) is marked by a decline in settlement and a deterioration of government. To the rising power of the Bedouins – an important process of the period – there are echoes in Transjordan, the Jordan Valley and East Manasseh. In a large number of encampment sites in East Manasseh pottery dating to the Mameluk and Early Ottoman periods was detected, a fact related to the prosperity of the Bedouins in the area (Drori 1981, 28-29).

The decline of the sedentary settlement seems to have continued during the Ottoman period. Following the Ottoman conquest of the country (1516 CE) there is some local prosperity, yet the general decline continues. In the cen-

sus of 1596 CE published by Hutteroth and Abd el-Fatah (1977) the *Liwa* (territory) of Nablus is divided into the *Nahia* (region) Jebel Shami – the hilly area with Nablus – and the *Nahia* of the *Ghor* (the Jordan Valley). The latter was joined to the Ajlun district in Transjordan. In the first *Nahia* the villages of Taiyasir, 'Aqaba, Tammun, Tubas, Sir, Kfer and Miskeh (probably Bet Farr (B)) are mentioned as settled places. Of the present villages, Zebabdeh, Rabbah and Tilfit are not mentioned.

Conder and Kitchener of the PEF note that in the end of the 19th century most of the settlement was Bedouin. In 1874 (SWP II, 227-229) all the present villages are mentioned, along with Kh. 'Atuf (no. 131) and Kh. Qa'un (Zertal 2005, site 3), both unsettled today. They add that in the Wadi Malih region tribes of the Bal'uni, Sardiyeh and Fuheilat are settled, all of Transjordanian origin. The Buqe'ah and Wadi Malih were cultivated by fellahin from Tubas and Taiyasir, together with Bedouins from the Masa'id tribe. The most important families in this period at Tubas are those of the Daragmeh, Sawafteh and Fuqahah. The SWP mentioned also some Christians (Greek Catholics).